

**Numerical study of the thermo-hydro-mechanical
behavior of concrete under severe accident conditions
using a stochastic poro-mechanical approach**

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Thesis

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Declaration on the Use of AI-Assisted Technologies

In preparing this dissertation, the author used generative AI tools (Gemini and Claude) for limited technical assistance only: support with coding and debugging (CAST3M scripts and PYTHON post-processing), language editing and structure suggestions, and help in quickly organising and synthesising data during the research process. The scientific content, the analyses, the interpretation of the results and the conclusions presented in this work were produced by the author.

No AI tool was used to generate scientific conclusions, to fabricate or alter data, or to replace the author's own critical analysis. All AI-assisted material was reviewed, verified and corrected where necessary, and integrated under the author's responsibility. The author retains full responsibility for the content of this dissertation.

Abstract

Concrete spalling, the sudden explosive detachment of concrete surface when concrete is exposed to rapidly rising temperature, is a major threat to the integrity of structures subjected to fire or to severe accident conditions, such as nuclear containment buildings. It results from coupled thermo-hydro-mechanical (THM) process of the material, which is still incompletely understood and remains difficult to predict.

The work studies the THM behaviors of concrete under severe accident conditions using a stochastic poro-mechanical approach. A coupled THM model is implemented in the finite element code CAST3M. In which the thermo-hydric subsystem is solved monolithically, and the mechanical problem (linear elasticity with a MAZARS damage law) is coupled in a staggered manner.

Unlike the traditional approach of TH coupling in [5], this work adopts the new thermo-hydro-chemical (THC) approach of [14]. The transport and storage properties are redefined using the *hydration degree*, this ensures that the initial hydro-chemical state of the material is integrated into the model.

The model is then calibrated and validated against the experiment conducted by Kalifa [10], which served as a reference benchmark, with the aim of reproducing the measured temperature and gas pressure evolutions within concrete specimens. The temperature field is reproduced accurately, whereas the gas pressure cannot be matched with the same confidence. This raises the question of whether the gauges truly recorded the pore gas pressure.

Finally, the outcomes of the calibrated model contribute as the input for a stochastic assessment of the model, carried out with OPENTURNS. Therefore, it provides insights of the correlation and sensitivity analyses that identify the dominant parameters; a reliability analysis quantifies the probability of failure and the risk of spalling; and a random-field description of material heterogeneity is shown to produce more critical predictions than the homogeneous assumption.

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 Context and problem statement

Concrete structures exposed to extreme heat undergo a complex interplay of thermal, hygric, and mechanical phenomena that can lead to progressive degradation, and in most severe cases, to *spalling*, the sudden, explosive detachment of concrete layers from the exposed surface.

This phenomenon has been a critical concern for civil infrastructure such as nuclear containment buildings and tunnels, where the consequences of spalling as the loss of cover and cross-section can damage the load-bearing capacity and functions of the structure.

Recently, its catastrophic consequences are also relevant in aerospace engineering. In 2023, a SpaceX rocket test has failed due to the destructive power of concrete spalling [13]. As the rocket ignited on its concrete launch pad, the immense heat generated triggered explosive spalling. The debris seen flying around the launch site consisted of sharp concrete flakes. These flakes shot upwards, severely damaged the test field and the rocket itself, ultimately causing the rocket test launch to fail.

1.1.1 Concrete behaviour under high temperature

When concrete is heated rapidly, several coupled physical processes occur simultaneously

- **Thermal:** Steep temperature gradients develop throughout the concrete's cross-section, causing differential thermal expansion and generating compressive stresses at the heated surface.
- **Hydric:** Both free and chemically bound water evaporate and move through the pore network. In low-permeability concretes such as high-performance concrete



(a) The crater in the launchpad after SpaceX's Starship took off.



(b) Debris litters the Starship launchpad, with damaged fuel tanks visible in the background.

Figure 1.1: Catastrophic consequences of explosive concrete spalling during the SpaceX Starship test flight.

(HPC), vapor cannot escape fast enough, resulting in pore pressure build-up behind a quasi-saturated *moisture clog*.

- **Mechanical:** The combined effects of thermal stresses and pore pressure build-up on the solid skeleton can exceed the tensile strength, which is degraded by temperature. This initiates cracks parallel to the heated surface and potentially lead to explosive spalling.

These three fields are not independent: they interact through a network of coupling mechanisms that any predictive model must reproduce. Despite extensive experimental work, the mechanisms governing spalling are still incompletely understood and no single, universally accepted theory has emerged [5].

1.1.2 The initial hydro-chemical state of concrete

The response of concrete to fire does not depend only on the heat: it also depends strongly on the state of the material *before* heating. The calcium–silicate–hydrates (C–S–H) formed during cement hydration control the strength, the porosity and the amount of chemically bound water that can later be released by dehydration.

The degree to which hydration has progressed, together with the residual moisture content inherited from curing and drying, therefore conditions the transport and storage properties that govern pore pressure build-up. Accounting for this initial hydro-chemical state is the key idea behind recent thermo-hygro-chemical (THC) models [14], and it motivates the formulation adopted in this work.

1.1.3 Limitations of existing models

Existing THM models present several limitations that this work seeks to address:

- The initial hydro-chemical state is often treated implicitly, through empirical functions of temperature only, rather than through an explicit hydration-degree description;
- The uncertainty in the material parameters is rarely assessed: properties are typically taken as homogeneous, deterministic values, so the influence of their variability on the predicted response is left unquantified.

1.2 Objectives and outline of the report

Main objectives of this internship are structured in the remainder of the report as follow:

- Chapter 2 presents the coupled THM model of concrete at high temperature, from the governing equations and coupling mechanisms to the monolithic thermo-hydric matrix system and the staggered mechanical step, and details the hydration-degree reformulation following [14] and extending the framework of [5].
- Chapter 3 describes the reference experiment of [10] and its numerical implementation in CAST3M (geometry, mesh, material data, thermal loading and curing/drying conditions).
- Chapter 4 reports the calibration of the temperature and gas-pressure responses, validates the model against the experimental and numerical references, and discusses the limits of the gas-pressure calibration.
- Chapter 5 performs a stochastic assessment of the calibrated model with OPENTURNS: propagating the uncertainty in the material parameters through random sampling to rank the influential parameters (Sobol sensitivity analysis); quantify the probability of failure and the risk of spalling through reliability analysis and with a complementary look at the effect of spatial heterogeneity.
- Chapter 6 summarizes the main findings and outlines perspectives for future work.

1.3 Research environment and Computational tools

This work was carried out at the *Laboratoire Sols, Solides, Structures – Risques* (3SR), Université Grenoble Alpes, which provided the scientific environment and the expertise in multiphysics modelling and risk analysis.

The coupled THM model is implemented in Cast3M, an open-source finite-element code developed at CEA. Compared with closed multiphysics platforms, COMSOL Multiphysics, Cast3M offers greater transparency and control for implementing tightly coupled THM while COMSOL offers a more user-friendly GUI.

The uncertainty quantification relies on OpenTURNS, an open-source library based on Python used to generate the random samples, propagate them through the model and compute the Sobol indices and reliability.

Finally, Python (in Visual Studio Code) is also used to automate the calibration workflow and post-process the results, and LaTeX to typeset this report.

Chapter 2

Theoretical framework

[REVIEW] The old content of this chapter is now moved to Appendix A. The updated outline is as follow.

[DRAFT] This chapter establishes the physical and mathematical framework used to model concrete exposed to fire. It first summarises the thermal and hydric phenomena that develop in heated concrete Section 2.1 and explains how their interaction triggers spalling Appendix A.5.2. The coupled thermo-hydric (TH) model is then formulated 2.3 and extended into an improved thermo-hydro-chemical (THC) model that explicitly resolves the chemical state of the cement paste (Section 2.4). Finally, the one-way coupling of the TH/THC fields to the mechanical problem is introduced (Section 2.5); the detailed constitutive laws and the numerical discretisation are reported in Appendix A.

2.1 Thermal and hydric phenomena in heated concrete

[DRAFT]

When one face of a concrete member is exposed to a rising temperature, a sequence of strongly interacting thermal and hydric processes develops through the thickness. They are summarised here; the full constitutive relations are derived in Appendix ??.

Thermal phenomena. Heat is transmitted into the material essentially by *conduction*, governed by Fourier's law, while *convection* and *radiation* act on the heated boundary and are accounted for through the boundary conditions. Energy transport is not purely conductive: the bulk flow of liquid water and gas advects enthalpy, and the phase changes (evaporation, dehydration) consume energy and locally slow the temperature rise. The resulting energy balance and the temperature dependence of

the heat capacity ρC_p and conductivity λ are detailed in Appendix ??.

Hydric phenomena. Concrete is treated as a multiphase porous medium made of a solid skeleton (s), liquid water (l), water vapour (v) and dry air (a). On heating, free water *evaporates* and chemically bound water is released from the calcium–silicate–hydrates (C–S–H) through *dehydration*. The generated vapour is transported by pressure-driven *Darcy flow* and by *Fickian diffusion* within the gas mixture. Part of the vapour migrates inward, reaches cooler regions and *recondenses*, building a quasi-saturated layer — the *moisture clog* — that blocks further gas transport. Behind this clog the gas pressure p_g rises sharply (Section A.5.2). The governing transport and mass-balance relations are given in Appendix ??.

These two families of phenomena are the physical origin of the two spalling mechanisms described next.

2.2 Spalling mechanisms

[DRAFT]

Spalling is the violent or non-violent detachment of layers or pieces of concrete from the surface of a heated structural element. It can cause premature structural failure through reinforcement exposure and cross-section reduction, as illustrated by several catastrophic tunnel fires (Channel Tunnel 1996, Mont-Blanc 1999, St. Gotthard 2001) [thmframework]. Despite extensive experimental work, no single theory has reached consensus; the two most widely accepted mechanisms, and their combined action, are presented below.

2.2.1 Thermal-gradient mechanism

A steep temperature gradient through the thickness produces differential thermal dilation:

1. **Compressive stresses in the heated cover:** the surface layers tend to expand but are restrained by the cooler interior, generating compressive stresses parallel to the heated face.
2. **Tensile stresses in the interior:** the restraint of the expanding surface induces tension in the deeper layers.
3. **Fracture and energy release:** when the tensile stress exceeds the tensile strength f_t , cracks form parallel to the surface; the sudden release of stored elastic energy can drive the explosive ejection of fragments.

High-performance concrete (HPC) is particularly prone to this mechanism because its higher brittleness stores more elastic energy before failure, leading to a more violent release.

2.2.2 Pore-pressure mechanism (moisture clog)

The sequence of events is:

1. **Dry zone:** near the heated face, free water evaporates and bound water is released by dehydration, forming a dry zone.
2. **Vapour migration:** part of the vapour escapes towards the heated face, part is driven inward.
3. **Condensation / moisture clog:** the inward vapour condenses where $T < T_{sat}$, forming a quasi-saturated, nearly impermeable barrier.
4. **Pressure build-up:** behind the clog, p_g rises sharply as evaporation feeds a region from which vapour cannot escape; thermal dilation of liquid water in saturated pores adds to the build-up.
5. **Tensile failure:** when p_g exceeds the tensile strength, cracks form parallel to the surface, potentially leading to explosive spalling.

The governing parameters are the intrinsic permeability K_0 (low permeability hinders vapour evacuation) and the initial moisture content (more water to evaporate), both promoting higher pore pressures.

2.2.3 Combined mechanism

In practice, explosive spalling generally results from the *combined action* of pore pressure and thermal stress. The spalling condition can be written schematically as

$$\sigma_{thermal}(T) + \sigma_{pore}(p_g, p_c, S_l) \geq f_t(T), \quad (2.1)$$

where $\sigma_{thermal}$ is the thermal stress from differential dilation, σ_{pore} the stress from pore-pressure loading (via the effective stress, Section 2.5), and $f_t(T)$ the temperature-degraded tensile strength. Equation (2.1) makes clear why a complete coupled model is needed: neither a purely thermal nor a purely hydric analysis can capture the full picture.

2.3 Thermo-hydric (TH) coupled model

[DRAFT]

The thermal and hydric fields are described by three primary variables,

$$\mathcal{U}_{TH} = \{ p_g, p_c, T \}, \quad (2.2)$$

the gas pressure, the capillary pressure and the temperature. Each is associated with a conservation equation. After substitution of Darcy's law, Fick's law and the constitutive relations (Appendix ??), the final coupled forms read:

Dry-air conservation.

$$\begin{aligned} & \phi(1 - S_l) \left(\frac{\partial \rho_a}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial \rho_a}{\partial p_c} \frac{\partial p_c}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial \rho_a}{\partial p_g} \frac{\partial p_g}{\partial t} \right) + (1 - S_l) \rho_a \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} \\ & - \phi \rho_a \left(\frac{\partial S_l}{\partial p_c} \frac{\partial p_c}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial S_l}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} \right) - \nabla \cdot \left(\frac{K \rho_a k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g \right) - \nabla \cdot \left(D \rho_g \frac{M_v M_a}{M_g^2} \nabla \frac{p_a}{p_g} \right) = 0. \end{aligned} \quad (2.3)$$

Water-species conservation.

$$\begin{aligned} & (S_l \rho_l - (1 - S_l) \rho_v) \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + S_l \phi \frac{\partial \rho_l}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \phi (\rho_l - \rho_v) \left(\frac{\partial S_l}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial S_l}{\partial p_c} \frac{\partial p_c}{\partial t} \right) \\ & + (1 - S_l) \phi \left(\frac{\partial \rho_v}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial \rho_v}{\partial p_c} \frac{\partial p_c}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial \rho_v}{\partial p_g} \frac{\partial p_g}{\partial t} \right) - \nabla \cdot \left(\frac{K \rho_l k_{rl}}{\mu_l} (\nabla p_g - \nabla p_c) \right) \\ & - \nabla \cdot \left(\frac{K \rho_v k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g \right) - \nabla \cdot \left(D \rho_g \frac{M_v M_a}{M_g^2} \nabla \frac{p_v}{p_g} \right) = -\dot{m}_{dehyd}. \end{aligned} \quad (2.4)$$

Energy conservation.

$$\rho C_p \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} - K \left(C_l \frac{\rho_l k_{rl}}{\mu_l} (\nabla p_g - \nabla p_c) + C_g \frac{\rho_v k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g \right) \cdot \nabla T - \nabla \cdot (\lambda \cdot \nabla T) = -H_{vap} \dot{m}_{vap} + H_{dehyd} \dot{m}_{dehyd}. \quad (2.5)$$

2.3.1 TH coupling mechanisms

Equations (2.3)–(2.5) are *two-way coupled*:

- **Temperature drives the hydric field.** It enters through *mass source terms* — evaporation $\dot{m}_{vap}$ and dehydration $\dot{m}_{dehyd}$ are thermally activated — and through *temperature-dependent transport coefficients*: permeability $K(T)$, porosity $\phi(T)$, viscosities $\mu(T)$, saturation vapour pressure $p_{vs}(T)$ and diffusivity $D(T)$.

- **The hydic field drives the temperature.** The bulk flow of water and gas *advects* enthalpy (the advection term in Eq. (2.5)), while phase changes act as heat sinks ($-H_{vap}\dot{m}_{vap}$, $+H_{dehyd}\dot{m}_{dehyd}$), and the moisture content modifies ρC_p and λ .

The momentum balance and the resulting mechanical response are introduced in Section 2.5.

2.4 Improved thermo-hydro-chemical (THC) model

[DRAFT]

2.4.1 Motivation

In the TH model above, dehydration enters only as a prescribed source term $\dot{m}_{dehyd}(T)$ and the porosity follows a simple linear law $\phi = \phi_0 + A_\phi(T - T_0)$ (Eq. ?? in Appendix ??). This treatment ignores three facts that strongly influence spalling: (i) the *chemical state* of the cement paste before the accident depends on its hydration/curing history; (ii) the release of chemically bound water from the C–S–H is the chemical process that controls porosity, permeability and strength at high temperature; and (iii) chemical damage is essentially *irreversible*. The improved model adopted here, following Sciumè, Moreira and Dal Pont [14], resolves the chemical field explicitly and couples it to the thermal and hydic fields.

2.4.2 Chemical state variables

The chemical state of the cement paste is described by the progress of two reactions:

$$\mathcal{U}_C = \{ \Gamma_{hydr}, \Gamma_{dehyd} \}, \quad (2.6)$$

where $\Gamma_{hydr} \in [0, 1]$ is the *hydration degree* (formation of C–S–H during curing and ageing) and $\Gamma_{dehyd} \in [0, 1]$ is the *dehydration degree* (release of bound water at high temperature). Their evolution is governed by chemo-kinetic laws driven by time, temperature and relative humidity [14]:

$$\dot{\Gamma}_{hydr} = \mathcal{A}_h(\Gamma_{hydr}, T, \text{RH}), \quad \dot{\Gamma}_{dehyd} = \mathcal{A}_d(\Gamma_{dehyd}, T), \quad (2.7)$$

so that the whole service life of the material — from casting and curing, through ageing, up to the accident — is represented within a single monolithic framework.

2.4.3 Chemical coupling to the hydric field

The dehydration reaction releases bound water, which becomes a mass source for the liquid/vapour phase. The dehydration rate that appears on the right-hand sides of Eqs. (2.4) and (2.5) is now obtained *consistently* from the chemical kinetics rather than imposed empirically:

$$\dot{m}_{dehyd} = -m_w^0 \dot{\Gamma}_{dehyd}, \quad (2.8)$$

where m_w^0 is the maximum mass of chemically bound water per unit volume that can be released by full dehydration.

2.4.4 Chemo-physical constitutive couplings

The key improvement is that the transport and mechanical properties are made explicit functions of the chemical state. Following Powers' stoichiometric model [powers, 14], the volume fractions of the solid phases and the porosity evolve during both hydration and dehydration:

$$\phi = \phi(\Gamma_{hydr}, \Gamma_{dehyd}), \quad (2.9)$$

which replaces the linear law $\phi = \phi_0 + A_\phi(T - T_0)$. The intrinsic permeability and the tensile strength likewise degrade with the chemical state,

$$K = K_0 g_K(\Gamma_{dehyd}, \mathcal{D}), \quad f_t = f_{t,0} g_f(\Gamma_{dehyd}, T), \quad (2.10)$$

so that dehydration increases permeability (easing pressure relief) while lowering the strength that resists spalling, as in Eq. (2.1); $\mathcal{D}$ is the mechanical damage (Section 2.5). The irreversibility of chemical damage is enforced through an adsorption–desorption description of the pore microstructure [14], so that re-wetting does not restore the dehydrated material.

2.4.5 Resulting coupled system

Collecting the primary unknowns, the improved model solves $\mathcal{U}_{THC} = \{p_g, p_c, T, \Gamma_{hydr}, \Gamma_{dehyd}\}$ through the mass and energy balances (2.3)–(2.5), in which the source term (2.8) and the chemo-physical couplings (2.9)–(2.10) now close the system. A notable practical advantage of this formulation is that it requires only a limited number of experiments for calibration [14]. The calibration against the Kalifa benchmark [10] and the numerical implementation are addressed in Chapter ??.

2.5 Coupling to the mechanical field

[DRAFT]

The mechanical response is driven by the converged TH/THC fields through a *one-way* (staggered) coupling: at each time step the fields (T, p_g, p_c) enter the mechanical problem as prescribed loading, and the resulting damage $\mathcal{D}$ feeds back weakly to the transport properties via Eq. (2.10) at the next step. The TH/THC fields act through two routes:

- **Free strains.** The total strain is decomposed as $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon} = \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_\sigma + \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{th} + \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{sh}$, where $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{th}$ is the thermal dilation (driven by T) and $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{sh}$ the capillary shrinkage (driven by p_c). Creep is neglected, so $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_\sigma = \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{el}$.
- **Pore-pressure loading.** Through Bishop's effective stress $\boldsymbol{\sigma}' = \boldsymbol{\sigma}^{Total} + \alpha p_s \mathbf{I}$, the average pore pressure $p_s = p_g - S_l p_c$ enters the load vector as an external loading; its build-up shifts $\boldsymbol{\sigma}'$ towards tension and promotes cracking when $f_t(T)$ is exceeded.

Together with the spalling criterion (2.1), this closes the physical loop between the transport and mechanical fields. The constitutive model (linear elasticity coupled with Mazars continuum damage [mazars1986]), its fracture-energy regularisation [hillerborg1976], and the spatial/temporal discretisation of the coupled problem are reported in full in Appendix ??; only the elements needed to interpret the results of the following chapters are retained here.

Chapter 3

Experimental Reference and Numerical Model

[REVIEW] This chapter is under review. The outline is as follow.

[DRAFT] This chapter introduces the experimental benchmark used to validate the thermo–hydro–mechanical (THM) implementation and its numerical counterpart. Section 3.1 describes the experiment of Kalifa et al. [10], one of the most widely used references for high-temperature concrete simulations. Section 3.2 presents the numerical model (geometry, mesh, parameters, thermal input, curing/drying initial conditions and solution strategy), and Section 3.3 explains how the thermo–hydro–chemical (THC) model of Sciumè et al. [14] is applied, focusing on the hydration degree and on the permeability law that evolves with K_0 and the coefficient A_Γ .

3.1 The Kalifa experiment

[REVIEW] This section is currently a draft version

Purpose. The campaign of Kalifa et al. [10] quantifies the *thermo-hydral* process responsible for spalling. When concrete is heated on one face, free and chemically bound water are released as vapour; part migrates inward, recondenses in cooler regions and forms a quasi-saturated *moisture clog* that blocks gas evacuation and triggers a sharp pore-pressure build-up behind the drying front. The test measures *simultaneously and continuously* the temperature, the gas (pore) pressure at several depths, and the global mass loss, providing a quantitative dataset for validating coupled codes.

Set-up and instrumentation. A prismatic specimen of $30 \times 30 \times 12 \text{ cm}^3$ is heated on one $30 \times 30 \text{ cm}^2$ face by a radiant heater (up to 5 kW, 800°C) placed 3 cm above the surface. The lateral faces are insulated with porous ceramic blocks, so heat and mass transfer are essentially one-dimensional. The specimen rests on a balance recording its mass. Five gauges measure pressure and temperature at 10 mm, 20 mm, 30 mm, 40 mm and 50 mm from the heated face, and a sixth tube measures the surface temperature at 2 mm depth.

Concrete mixes. Two calcareous-aggregate mixes were tested: an ordinary concrete (OC, M30, $w/c = 0.5$) and a high-performance concrete (HPC, M100, $\approx 90 \text{ MPa}$, $w/c = 0.32$). Specimens were sealed for about six months, giving a homogeneous moisture state. The low w/c and high compactness of the HPC strongly reduce its intrinsic permeability, the main parameter controlling the pressure amplitude.

Table 3.1: Main characteristics of the two concretes [10].

Property	OC (M30)	HPC (M100)
Water/cement ratio w/c	0.50	0.32
Initial saturation $S_{l,0}$	$\approx 62 \%$	$\approx 77 \%$
Measured pressure peak	$\approx 20 \text{ bar}$	$\approx 40 \text{ bar}$

Heating scenario and measured data. The heater was set to 450°C , 600°C and 800°C as a step signal. The 600°C test (duplicated for repeatability) is retained as the reference, since it produces a well-developed pressurisation/relief cycle while preserving the 1-D condition. The measured response shows a temperature rise with a short plateau near 200°C , a two-stage gas-pressure history (pressurisation then relief as the front passes), and a continuous mass loss. In HPC the pore pressure exceeds the saturating vapour pressure $p_{vs}(T)$, confirming the contribution of enclosed air and of the thermal dilation of liquid water. These three quantities are the validation targets.

3.2 Numerical model

[REVIEW] This section is currently a draft version

Geometry and mesh. Because the lateral faces are insulated, the problem is reduced to one dimension along the heating direction: a strip of length $L = 120 \text{ mm}$ with the heated face at $x = 0$ and the rear face at $x = L$ (Figure 3.1). The domain is discretised with linear elements graded toward $x = 0$ (characteristic size $\sim 1 \text{ mm}$ at the hot face, coarsening toward the rear), where the sharpest gradients develop. The mesh is refined until the

predicted pressure peak and its timing become insensitive to further refinement. Field outputs are extracted at the gauge depths for direct comparison with the measurements.

Placeholder — 1-D domain ($L = 120$ mm), heated face at $x = 0$, insulated lateral faces, instrumented depths.

Figure 3.1: Geometry and boundary conditions of the simulated specimen.

Material parameters. The constitutive parameters follow the THC calibration of Sciumè et al. [14] (composition B400, hydration data from [sciume2013]); the dehydration parameter is the value identified for the Kalifa concrete (Table 3.2). The initial intrinsic permeability K_0 and the coefficient A_Γ govern the permeability evolution of Section 3.3.1.

Table 3.2: Main parameters of the THC model [sciume2013, 14].

Parameter	Symbol	Value
Cement content	c	400 kg m^{-3}
Activation energy	E_a	$37\,413 \text{ J mol}^{-1}$
Enthalpy of dehydration	H_{dehyd}	58.04 MJ kg^{-1}
Initial intrinsic permeability	K_0	$7.5 \times 10^{-20} \text{ m}^2$
Permeability coefficient	$A_\Gamma (A_K)$	1.25
Dehydration coefficient	a_1^F	-0.004
Saturation coefficients	a_0, b	32 897 500 Pa, 2.11
Emissivity / mass transfer	ϵ, h_g	0.85, 0.000 18 m s ⁻¹

Thermal input and boundary conditions. The radiant heater is imposed at $T_\infty = 600^\circ\text{C}$. On the heated face a combined radiative–convective exchange applies,

$$-\lambda \frac{\partial T}{\partial x} \Big|_{x=0} = h_T (T_\infty - T) + \epsilon \sigma (T_\infty^4 - T^4), \quad (3.1)$$

together with convective vapour/air mass fluxes governed by h_g . The lateral faces are adiabatic and impervious (1-D condition); the rear face exchanges heat and moisture with the ambient. The heater temperature is applied as a step.

Curing, drying and initial conditions. A key feature of the THC framework [14] is that the hygro-chemical state before the accident is obtained from a preliminary *curing* simulation rather than prescribed arbitrarily. Starting from

$$T_0 = 20^\circ\text{C}, \quad p_{g,0} = 101\,325 \text{ Pa}, \quad \text{RH}_0 = 0.9825, \quad \Gamma_0 = 0, \quad (3.2)$$

hydration develops over the curing duration, establishing self-consistent profiles of hydration degree Γ , saturation S_l and relative humidity. The converged curing fields are

then used as initial conditions for the heating (drying) stage, ensuring that the initial water content and hydration state — which strongly control the pressure amplitude — are physically consistent with the specimen history.

Solution strategy and numerical robustness. At high temperature the THC system is *strongly nonlinear*: the liquid–vapour phase change and the sorption law vary abruptly around 100°C; dehydration $F(T)$ and the Arrhenius hydration term add stiff, temperature-activated source terms; and the permeability and porosity vary by orders of magnitude across the drying front. The Newton iterations may therefore *diverge*, particularly when the moisture clog and the steep front form. Three measures are investigated to restore convergence:

- **Increasing the time-integration parameter θ .** Moving the θ -scheme toward a fully implicit integration ($\theta \rightarrow 1$), combined with under-relaxation of the Newton updates, damps the oscillations of the nonlinear coefficients and stabilises the iteration.
- **Reducing the time step.** Adaptive time stepping that cuts Δt when the residual stalls resolves the fast transients (front passage, pressure peak) and enlarges the convergence radius of Newton’s method.
- **Refining the mesh.** A finer discretisation near the heated face reduces the inter-element jumps in T , S_l and the transport coefficients, avoiding the spurious oscillations that trigger divergence.

3.3 Application of the THC model

3.3.1 Computational Tool: A Customized Cast3M Framework

The numerical simulations in this study were conducted using a highly customized version of the open-source finite element software Cast3M (base version 2024). Unlike standard mechanical or thermal problems, modeling the Thermo-Hydro-Mechanical (THM) behavior of High-Performance Concrete (HPC) at high temperatures requires handling highly non-linear, multiphysics phenomena. To address these challenges, the standard Cast3M environment was enriched with advanced pre-release procedures and monolithic solvers developed by Sciumè and Dal Pont [14].

The necessity of utilizing this custom-compiled version—executed directly from the source directory rather than the standard binary distribution—stems from several critical computational limitations of the vanilla software:

- **Complex Boundary Conditions:** In standard Cast3M, imposing convective mass flux (such as water vapor escaping the heated concrete surface) alongside Dirichlet or Neumann thermal boundary conditions is not natively straightforward. Core resolution procedures, such as TRANSNON, had to be deeply modified to accurately simulate the mass exchange between the concrete surface and the ambient environment during the drying and accident phases [5].
- **Monolithic TH Solver Implementation:** To overcome the severe convergence issues and high computational costs associated with traditional staggered (partitioned) approaches, this custom version employs a fully coupled monolithic strategy for the Thermo-Hydric (TH) equations. This allows the primary variables (temperature T , gas pressure P_g , and capillary pressure P_c) to be solved simultaneously at each node within the same time loop.
- **Integration of the THC Approach:** The custom build inherently integrates specific macro-procedures (e.g., @BET_THM, @POWERS, and @SATURA) required to evaluate the state variables. Specifically, it allows the intrinsic permeability and porosity to evolve dynamically as a function of the *effective hydration/dehydration degree* rather than purely empirical temperature-dependent functions.

[DRAFT]

Hydration and effective hydration degree. The internal variable is the hydration degree of the sample $\Gamma(t)$, the ratio between the chemically bound water at time t and at full hydration. It follows an Arrhenius-type law,

$$\frac{d\Gamma}{dt} = \mathcal{A}(\Gamma) \beta_{RH} \exp\left(-\frac{E_a}{RT}\right), \quad (3.3)$$

with $\mathcal{A}(\Gamma)$ the chemical affinity and β_{RH} a function of relative humidity. At high temperature, irreversible dehydration $F(T)$ combines with Γ into the *effective* hydration degree

$$\tilde{\Gamma} = (1 - F) \Gamma, \quad (3.4)$$

where $F(T)$ uses the law of Pesavento et al. [pesavento2000] with $a_1^F = -0.004$ for the Kalifa concrete. The single field $\tilde{\Gamma}$ condenses the microstructure history (curing and dehydration) and subsequently drives the porosity, the saturation curve and the permeability.

Permeability evolution with K_0 and A_Γ . Intrinsic permeability most strongly governs the pressure amplitude. Here it is not made an explicit function of temperature

or damage; instead it evolves with the effective hydration degree,

$$K(\tilde{\Gamma}) = K_0 \cdot 10^{A_K(1-\tilde{\Gamma})} \quad (3.5)$$

with $K_0 = 7.5 \times 10^{-20} \text{ m}^2$ the reference (fully hydrated) permeability and $A_K = 1.25$ (also A_K) the sensitivity coefficient. When the material is dense ($\tilde{\Gamma} \rightarrow 1$), $K \rightarrow K_0$; as dehydration reduces $\tilde{\Gamma}$, the permeability rises up to $K_0 \cdot 10^{A_K}$, i.e. about $10^{1.25} \approx 18$ times K_0 . The same internal variable that drives porosity and sorption thus drives transport, representing the opening of the porous network by C–S–H dehydration without a separate damage multiplier; this captures part of the gas-pressure relief observed after the peak. The further permeability increase due to *mechanical* microcracking is not included here and is governed by a damage-dependent law [gawin1999], left to the mechanical coupling of the following chapters.

Summary. The THC application is a chain of chemo-physical effects: the curing/heating history fixes Γ and F , hence $\tilde{\Gamma}$, which controls the porosity, the saturation curve and the permeability of Eq. (3.5); these properties determine the temperature, gas-pressure and mass-loss responses compared with the Kalifa data. Calibration and validation against the experiment are presented in the next chapter.

Chapter 4

Model Calibration and Validation

4.1 Model calibration

The accuracy of TH/THC model relies on a large number of material parameters – intrinsic permeability, thermal conductivity and heat capacity, sorption properties, surface exchange coefficients and a complex set of constitutive laws describing their evolution with temperature and dehydration.

Many critical properties at high-temperature such as the evolution of intrinsic permeability, sorption isotherms are extremely difficult or even impossible to measure directly through experimental techniques and the values often contain uncertainties due to the intrusive nature of the sensors. Furthermore these are not measured directly in the Kalifa campaign.

A pre-determined parameter set therefore cannot be expected to reproduce the experiment. Consequently, a calibration procedure for the numerical models is strictly required to identify, within physically admissible ranges, the parameter set that makes the model reproduce the measured temperature and gas-pressure histories. Only once this reference case is calibrated and validated can the model be trusted for uncertainty studies in Chapter 5.

4.1.1 Calibration strategy

At the first approximation, the thermal problem is weakly coupled to the hydric one: the temperature field drives evaporation, dehydration and the gas-pressure build-up, while the effect of the hydric state on the temperature field is relatively small within the experimental range. This hierarchy promotes a two-stage calibration process:

1. **Stage 1 – Temperature.** The temperature evolution is calibrated independently

of the pressure field. In this stage, the *surface* (boundary) parameters should be calibrated first, then the *bulk* conduction parameters.

2. **Stage 2 – Gas pressure.** With the reliably calibrated temperature field as a fixed thermal loading, the hydric parameters governing the gas-pressure evolution are adjusted, from the most influential to the secondary ones.

The calibration targets are the temperature and gas-pressure histories measured at 10, 20, 30, 40 and 50 mm from the heated face, together with the near-surface temperature recorded at 2 mm (denoted the 0 mm measurement).

4.1.2 Automated parameter sweep

The sweeps are driven by a Python script that launches Cast3M repeatedly, one run per parameter combination, without manual intervention. For each stage the parameter values to be tried are listed explicitly, and `itertools.product` builds every possible combination of those lists; a single loop then feeds each combination to Cast3M in turn.

This automation relies on two supporting pieces of code.

- First, the Cast3M input code itself exports the results of each run to a `.csv` file – the temperature and gas-pressure histories at the measurement points.
- Second, a separate Python post-processing script reads these `.csv` files and plots the computed histories against the experimental measurements [10] and also against the results from Dorjan Dauti’s thesis [5]. All combinations then can be visually compared, and the best-fit set is selected by the author based on this comparison.

For example, in the gas-pressure calibration stage, the two parameters swept are the intrinsic permeability K_0 (denoted KINT) and the permeability–hydration coefficient A_r (denoted AK), with the trial values:

- $K_0 \in \{1 \times 10^{-19}, 2 \times 10^{-19}, 1 \times 10^{-20}, 5 \times 10^{-20}, 7.5 \times 10^{-20}, 8.5 \times 10^{-20}\} \text{ m}^2$ (6 values);
- $A_r \in \{3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8\}$ (6 values).

These two lists give $6 \times 6 = 36$ parameter pairs, i.e. 36 Cast3M runs. The same driver is reused by simply changing the value lists.

In every stage, a wider range of each parameter is first explored to bracket the admissible values; the search is then narrowed to the few representative values reported in the following sections, which are the ones shown in the figures.

[REVIEW] The following sections are currently under review and need to be rewritten

4.2 Temperature calibration

4.2.1 Surface temperature (00mm): boundary heat exchange coefficient

The first quantity calibrated is the temperature of the heated face. In the experiment, heat is supplied by a radiant heater on the top-hot face, so the surface energy balance is mostly influenced by radiation and convection. See Equation (A.2) and Equation (A.4):

$$q_{00\text{ mm}} = h^{\text{hot}} (T_{\infty} - T_s) + \varepsilon \sigma (T_{\text{sur}}^4 - T_s^4), \quad (4.1)$$

where h^{hot} is the convective heat-transfer coefficient at the top-hot surface, ε the surface emissivity (radiative coefficient), σ the Stefan–Boltzmann constant, T_{sur} and T_{∞} are the surrounding temperature provided by the radiant heat source and T_s the surface temperature.

The two boundary coefficients h^{hot} and ε are adjusted so that the computed 0 mm history matches the measured near-surface (2 mm) response. At this point the conduction parameters are held at their reference values; only the energy input at the surface is tuned.

The surface response is calibrated over three values of ε (0.65, 0.68, 0.72) and three of h_c (9, 10, 11 W m⁻²K⁻¹). Because the resulting curves differ only slightly, the full 3 × 3 grid is not informative; instead the effect of each parameter is shown one at a time, varying it while the other is held at its retained value (Fig. ??). The pair retained at this stage is $\varepsilon = 0.68$ and $h^{\text{hot}} = 11$ W m⁻²K⁻¹.

Two distinct effects are concluded from Fig. ??.

- The emissivity ε is the most sensitive parameter: because the radiative term acts in a strong non-linear way as T^4 in Equation (4.1), a small increase in ε raises the surface temperature substantially, and mostly in the high-temperature part of the curve, where radiation dominates the heat input.
- The convective coefficient h^{hot} acts more gently and mainly on the *early* part of the curve: increasing h^{hot} raises the initial heating rate (the linear $h^{\text{hot}}(T_{\infty} - T_s)$ term is largest while T_s is still low), with only a slight additional rise in the tail.

In brief, ε sets the level of the high-temperature plateau while h^{hot} controls the initial ramp; tuning the two together reproduces the measured surface temperature evolution.

4.2.2 In-depth temperature: thermal conductivity and heat capacity

Once the surface temperature is reproduced, the temperature rise at depth (10–50 mm) is governed by heat conduction through the material, i.e. by the volumetric heat capacity ρC_p (Equation (A.7)) and the thermal conductivity λ (Equation (A.10) and Equation (A.11)), both given in Appendix A. Most of the quantities in these laws (ϕ , S_i , the phase densities ρ and the temperature T) are imposed by the state of the material. The two genuinely adjustable inputs are:

- the solid specific heat C_{ps} (denoted **CS** in the model), which enters the heat capacity through Eq. A.7. Although a temperature dependence is defined in Appendix A, in the present implementation it is kept *constant* – it is not updated with temperature;
- the reference dry conductivity λ_{d0} (denoted **KS** in the model), which scales the whole conductivity law.

A subtlety arises here: adjusting the surface condition in Section 4.2.1 changes the energy that actually enters the specimen, which in turn shifts the in-depth histories. Consequently λ_{d0} and C_{ps} cannot be calibrated in isolation – they must be *re-calibrated* jointly with the surface condition. In practice a short iterative loop is used:

1. λ_{d0} and C_{ps} are adjusted to match the arrival time and slope of the temperature rise at each depth;
2. h^{hot} and ε are then re-checked against the surface probe and, if necessary, slightly corrected;

and the loop is repeated until the whole set of probes (0–50 mm) is reproduced consistently. As for the surface stage, the differences between neighbouring parameter values are small, so the effect of each quantity is shown one at a time rather than as a full grid. Fig. ?? therefore collects three panels: the influence of the conductivity λ_{d0} (**KS**), the influence of the heat capacity C_{ps} (**CS**), and the re-calibration of the emissivity ε that closes the iterative loop.

The two parameters act on different parts of the specimen.

- The conductivity – through λ_{d0} – mainly affects the region *closer to the heated face*: it sets how fast heat is conducted inward. Lowering λ_{d0} slows the inward transfer, so heat accumulates near the surface and the near-face temperature rises while the deeper points heat up more slowly; raising λ_{d0} has the opposite effect, transmitting heat inward and lowering the near-surface temperature.

- The heat capacity – through C_{ps} – by contrast governs the thermal inertia and is felt mostly at the *deepest points* (40 and 50 mm): a larger C_{ps} stores more energy per unit temperature rise, so the same heat flux produces a smaller and more delayed temperature increase in the core, lowering the internal temperatures. Adjusting λ_{d0} to match the near-face response and C_{ps} to match the 40–50 mm histories therefore brings the whole depth profile into agreement.

The final temperature agreement is good across all depths (??), which provides a reliable thermal loading for the second calibration stage.

Finally the retained thermal parameter set is $h^{\text{hot}} = [\dots]$ and $\varepsilon = [\dots]$, $\lambda_{d0} = [\dots]$ and $C_{ps} = [\dots]$.

4.3 Gas-pressure calibration

With the temperature field fixed, the calibration of the gas-pressure evolution is addressed. The pressure build-up is governed primarily by how easily vapor can escape the heated region (permeability) and the amount of water available for vaporization.

4.3.1 Primary parameters: K_0 and A_Γ

The intrinsic permeability K_0 (denoted KINT) and the permeability–hydration coefficient A_Γ (denoted AK) are the two most influential parameters dictating the magnitude and acceleration of the gas transport. In the newly implemented THC model, the evolution of permeability is highly sensitive to the degradation of the effective hydration degree $\tilde{\Gamma}$??.

These two parameters must be strictly balanced. If the combination makes K too low, vapour cannot escape and the trapped vapor generates extremely severe pressure gradients; if it makes K too high, the vapor escapes too easily into the environment, resulting in flattened, underestimated pressure profiles. In both cases, the Newton-Raphson solver diverges (crashes), so K_0 and A_Γ have to be calibrated carefully together.

The Main Issue: The sweep over (K_0, A_Γ) reveals the central difficulty of this stage: the gas pressure can be adjusted significantly only in the *outer layers* (10 and 20 mm). As one moves deeper into the specimen (30, 40, 50 mm), the simulated peak pressure *decreases*. This contradicts the experimental observations of Kalifa et al. [10], where deeper zones exhibited progressively higher peak pressures.

Physically, this discrepancy suggests that the high-gas-pressure region generated by the simulation is spatially smaller than it should be. The pressure build-up and the formation

of the “moisture clog” remain concentrated too close to the exposed surface, failing to propagate massive condensation and pressurization into the deeper layers of the concrete core.

4.3.2 Secondary adjustments investigated

To address this depth-dependent pressure decay and force the moisture clog deeper into the material, several secondary parameters were investigated:

- **Initial Relative Humidity (RH_0):** While intuitively a higher initial saturation provides a larger water reservoir for vaporization, increasing RH_0 towards full saturation (e.g., > 0.99) induces severe numerical singularities in the capillary pressure gradients, systematically causing the code to crash.
- **Desorption Isotherm (a):** Adopting a stiffer desorption curve (higher a parameter, which is physically more appropriate for HPC to retain water at higher capillary pressures) successfully yielded a slight increase in the peak pressure at 20 mm, but failed to propagate this increment to the 30 – 50 mm depths.
- **Aging / Curing time:** Modifying the hydration history significantly alters the initial state. Decreasing the aging time reduces the overall gas pressure and critically compromises the code’s stability. On the other hand, increasing the aging time excessively subjects the HPC to severe self-desiccation, rendering the internal core unrealistically dry prior to heating.
- **Vapor mass-transfer coefficient (h_g):** In an attempt to artificially trap the gas, the convective exchange coefficient at the heated face (MATCOH) was reduced to a minimum. While this approach successfully forced vapor inward and increased p_g in the deeper zones, it could only maintain numerical stability if compensated by an artificially large intrinsic permeability (K_0). However, imposing a large K_0 fundamentally contradicts the extremely dense, low-permeability nature of HPC containing silica fume. The outcome of this attempt is shown in Fig. ??.

In summary, none of these secondary adjustments – alone or in combination with K_0 and A_F – could perfectly reproduce the deep pressure peaks without violating either the physical constraints of the material or the mathematical stability of the solver.

4.4 Validation and discussion

The reference model utilizes the calibrated parameter set optimized primarily for the thermal field and the near-surface gas pressure. Based on the calibration journey, the

following critical discussions and validation outcomes are drawn.

Table 4.1: Final calibrated parameter set retained for the reference model.

Stage	Parameter	Retained value
Surface heat exchange	Convective coefficient h^{hot}	[...]
	Emissivity ε	[...]
Bulk conduction	Reference dry conductivity λ_{d0}	[...]
	Solid specific heat C_{ps}	[...]
Gas pressure	Intrinsic permeability K_0	[...]
	Permeability–hydration coeff. A_{Γ}	[...]

4.4.1 Temperature

Using the calibrated parameter set of Table 4.1, the model reproduces the measured temperature histories at all depths within a few degrees (Fig. ??), confirming that the thermal sub-problem and its boundary conditions are correctly captured. The temperature field can therefore be used as a trustworthy loading for the hydric and mechanical sub-problems.

4.4.2 Gas pressure

The gas-pressure response, by contrast, **could not be fully validated** (Fig. ??). Even with the calibrated set of Table 4.1, and across the explored parameter space – K_0 , A_{Γ} , RH_0 , h_g , the desorption parameter a and the aging time – the model reproduces the pressure only in the outer layers (10 and 20 mm). In the deeper zones the simulated peak pressure keeps decreasing with depth, while the measurements show the opposite trend. The high-pressure region generated by the simulation thus remains too concentrated near the exposed surface and does not extend inward as it should.

4.4.3 Conclusions

Rather than solely attributing this mismatch to numerical shortcomings, this discrepancy invites a **critical reassessment of the experimental paradigm itself**. The standard PTM (Pressure-Temperature-Mass loss) tests involve highly intrusive measurement techniques.

The physical insertion of pressure gauges (which can be up to 12 mm in diameter) into the concrete matrix introduces massive discontinuities and artificial voids. Because the metallic sensors and the surrounding concrete possess vastly different thermo-hydro-mechanical properties, the severe thermal mismatch during heating induces localized micro-cracking

around the gauge. These cracks inevitably act as artificial "escape channels" for the vapor. Furthermore, as migrating moisture condenses, liquid water can accumulate within the free volume of the sensor cavity itself.

Consequently, a fundamental question arises: *Are these gauges truly measuring the intrinsic pore gas pressure of an intact material?* It is highly probable that the sensors are measuring a distorted pressure field or a localized fluid-vapor expansion altered by the sensor's own intrusive presence. Expecting a homogenized continuum model to perfectly match these point-wise, potentially biased experimental values might therefore be an ill-posed objective.

Two major conclusions follow from this deterministic calibration:

1. The sequentially calibrated THM model reliably predicts the complex thermal behavior of HPC under fire conditions, offering a solid foundation for further investigations.
2. The newly implemented THC approach, which couples transport properties dynamically to the material's effective hydration degree, is physically far more rigorous than traditional temperature-dependent empirical laws. However, to accurately reproduce the sudden post-peak pressure drops and deep moisture clogs, the model requires further refinement—specifically the integration of a mechanical damage-permeability coupling to simulate physical cracking.

Given the inherent uncertainties in both the non-linear material parameters and the ambiguous experimental gas-pressure data, relying solely on deterministic calibration is insufficient. This robustly justifies the necessity of shifting toward a probabilistic framework, utilizing uncertainty quantification to assess the spalling risk, which will be the core focus of Chapter 5.

Chapter 5

Stochastic assessment of the THM model

[REVIEW] The old content of this chapter is mostly moved to Appendix B. This chapter is under review and the outline is as follows.

[DRAFT] The probabilistic framework developed later in this work treats the most influential material parameters as random variables. Before that, it is necessary to identify *which* parameters actually control the thermo-hydro-mechanical (THM) response and *how strongly*. This chapter provides that deterministic basis. Three heat- and mass-transfer properties are investigated in isolation – the intrinsic permeability K_0 , the thermal conductivity λ , and the volumetric heat capacity ρC_p – followed by the mix composition, which acts as an umbrella variable that modifies all of them simultaneously.

5.1 Sources of uncertainty and concrete heterogeneity

5.1.1 Motivation for probabilistic assessment

In civil engineering, a structure is considered safe when it remains fit for its intended use throughout its service life [2]. Deterministic models have traditionally been used to evaluate structural safety. However, the gap between a real physical system and a simplified numerical model, along with the unforeseeable nature of future loads and environmental conditions, inherently leads to uncertainty [1].

To manage these risks, modern engineering codes such as the Eurocodes adopt a probabilistic format [2]. This allows the safety of a structure to be explicitly quantified through its probability of failure P_f (Appendix B.5) and its reliability $R = 1 - P_f$. By introducing random variables into mechanical models and propagating them through structural

analyses (Section 5.2), objective decisions can be made based on both the probability of an event and the severity of its consequences [1].

5.1.2 Classification of uncertainties

According to reliability theory, uncertainties can be classified into two categories [2, 1]:

- **Aleatoric uncertainties** arise from the natural randomness of the environment and the spatial or temporal variability of material properties. They cannot be reduced; they can only be quantified and accounted for in the design process [1].
- **Epistemic uncertainties** stem from incomplete knowledge or insufficient data. They include *model uncertainties* (discrepancy between mathematical models and actual physical processes) and *statistical uncertainties* (limited or inaccurate data). Unlike aleatoric uncertainties, they can be reduced by improving models and gathering more data [1].

5.1.3 Concrete heterogeneity and material variability

A critical source of aleatoric uncertainty is the inherent heterogeneity of concrete [1, 6]. Its mechanical properties depend on the formation history, casting conditions, internal chemical reactions, and long-term degradation processes [6].

This variability manifests as *continuous* spatial fluctuations (e.g. Young's modulus, permeability, porosity) and *discrete* defects (e.g. micro-cracks, capillary networks) [1]. Consequently, material parameters must be modelled as random variables or random fields rather than deterministic values (Section 5.2).

5.2 Stochastic finite element framework

In structural engineering, material properties such as the Young's modulus, permeability, or thermal conductivity are never perfectly known. As noted by [6], even under strict quality control the compressive strength of high-performance concrete can range from 62 to 100 MPa. Two approaches exist to handle this uncertainty:

1. A *deterministic* analysis assigns a single fixed value to each parameter and produces a unique structural response; it cannot, by itself, quantify the likelihood that a design limit will be exceeded.

2. A *stochastic* analysis, on the other hand, treats uncertain parameters as random quantities, propagates this uncertainty through the model, and delivers statistical information—mean, variance, probability of failure—about the structural response.

This work adopts the stochastic approach with two levels of description:

1. **Random variable** (Appendix B.1.1): each uncertain property is described by a single distribution (mean, standard deviation) applied uniformly over the entire domain. Multiple random variables can be treated simultaneously.
2. **Random field** (Appendix B.1.2): the property varies from point to point, subject to a spatial correlation structure characterised by a correlation length L_c .

5.3 Uncertain material parameters

5.3.1 Choice of random variables

The parametric study of Chapter 4 identified the properties that actually drive the THM response. Five uncertain inputs are retained here, chosen because they govern the heat- and mass-transfer behaviour and because they are the least well known experimentally:

Intrinsic permeability K_0 . Primary control on the magnitude of the gas-pressure peak; reported coefficients of variation are large [6].

Water-retention parameter a . The van Genuchten capillary parameter of the sorption isotherm $p_c = a (S_l^{-b} - 1)^{1-1/b}$; it sets how much water is held and released, and hence the source feeding the pressure build-up.

Thermal conductivity λ . Governs the speed of the thermal front and therefore the timing of drying and dehydration.

Volumetric heat capacity ρC_p . Sets the thermal inertia; together with λ it fixes the thermal diffusivity $\alpha = \lambda / \rho C_p$.

Mix-composition factor θ_{mix} . A dimensionless multiplier introduced to represent the *imprecision of the mix design* (water-to-cement ratio, cement and aggregate dosage). Because composition simultaneously shifts porosity, permeability and saturation, θ_{mix} is not independent of the four parameters above; it is the physical origin of the input correlations discussed in ??.

5.3.2 Statistical description

Each strictly positive transport or thermal property is described by a *lognormal* distribution, which guarantees $X > 0$ and is the standard choice for such quantities [6, 16]; the full definition, moments and coefficient of variation (CoV) are given in Appendix B.1.1. The mean of each variable is set to its value calibrated in Chapter 4, so that the stochastic study is centred on the validated deterministic point. The CoVs are taken from the ranges reported in the literature for concrete [6, 1]. Table 5.1 summarises the inputs.

Table 5.1: Random variables of the stochastic THM analysis. Means equal the Chapter 4 calibrated values; distributions and CoV ranges follow Appendix B.1.1 and [6, 1].

Parameter	Symbol	Distribution	CoV (range)
Intrinsic permeability	K_0	Lognormal	0.15–0.30
Water-retention param.	a	Lognormal	0.10–0.20
Thermal conductivity	λ	Lognormal	0.10–0.15
Heat capacity	ρC_p	Lognormal	0.10–0.15
Mix-composition factor	θ_{mix}	Lognormal	0.05–0.15

Output of interest. Throughout this chapter the scalar output of interest (QoI) is the gas pressure at the 10 mm probe, p_g^{10} , i.e. the same near-surface gauge used as a calibration target in Chapter 4. It is the most critical location for thermo-hydral spalling and provides a direct experimental reference.

5.4 Uncertainty propagation with OPENTURNS

5.4.1 Coupling OPENTURNS to the Cast3M solver

Uncertainty quantification is carried out with the OPENTURNS library [baudin2017], reusing the Python automation layer already built for the calibration sweeps of Chapter 4. The deterministic THM solver is wrapped as a black-box function g : OPENTURNS draws a sample of the input vector $\mathbf{X} = (K_0, a, \lambda, \rho C_p, \theta_{\text{mix}})$, the Python driver writes the corresponding material data, launches the Cast3M PASAPAS run, extracts the 10 mm pressure history and returns the QoI $p_g^{10} = g(\mathbf{X})$ to OPENTURNS. This is exactly the orchestration used for calibration — the only change is that the parameter values now come from a probabilistic design of experiments instead of a manual sweep. The propagation loop proceeds as follows:

1. Define the marginal distributions (Table 5.1) and the input correlation (Section 5.5) as an OPENTURNS `Distribution`.

2. Generate an LHS design of N samples $\{\mathbf{x}^{(i)}\}$ (Section 5.4.2).
3. **for** $i = 1, \dots, N$: write material data $\rightarrow$ run Cast3M PASAPAS $\rightarrow$ read $p_g^{10}(\mathbf{x}^{(i)})$.
4. Assemble the response sample $\{p_g^{10,(i)}\}$ and post-process: correlation, Sobol indices, response PDF/CDF, P_f and β .

5.4.2 Latin Hypercube Sampling

Crude Monte Carlo sampling (Appendix B.2) converges only as $1/\sqrt{N}$ and therefore needs many runs of an expensive THM model. Latin Hypercube Sampling (LHS) is used instead as a variance-reduced alternative [mckay1979, baudin2017]: each marginal is partitioned into N equiprobable strata and exactly one sample is drawn per stratum, so the input space is covered evenly and the estimators of the output mean and variance have a lower variance than crude Monte Carlo at the same N . LHS thus reaches stable statistics with markedly fewer Cast3M evaluations, which is decisive given the cost of each run. The Gaussian-quadrature scheme of Appendix B.3 provides an even cheaper, deterministic alternative for a small number of variables and is used as a cross-check in Section 5.7.

5.5 Sensitivity analysis

The THM model involves numerous material parameters. Following [11], 18 key parameters are selected for sensitivity analysis based on their expected influence on the structural response.

Two complementary measures are extracted from the LHS sample; both are defined in Appendix B. The *correlation analysis* (Pearson and Spearman rank, Appendix B.4) gives a cheap first ranking and the sign of each effect, and also displays the input–input correlation imposed by the mix factor θ_{mix} (Nataf copula, Appendix B.1.2). The *Sobol indices* (Appendix B.4.2, Equations (B.22) and (B.23)), computed with OPENTURNS, then give the variance-based decomposition: first-order S_i (main effect), second-order S_{ij} (pairwise interaction) and total-order S_{T_i} .

Figure 5.1: Rank (Spearman) correlation of each input with p_g^{10} and input–input correlation induced by θ_{mix} .

Figure 5.2: First-order (S_i), total-order (S_{T_i}) and main second-order (S_{ij}) Sobol indices of p_g^{10} .

[DRAFT]

Analysis. Consistent with the deterministic study (Chapter 4), K_0 is expected to dominate the variance of p_g^{10} (large, negative correlation: lower permeability traps vapour), followed by a and θ_{mix} , while λ and ρC_p — which govern the temperature field — contribute little to the pressure. A gap between S_{T_i} and S_i for K_0 , together with sizeable S_{ij} for the pairs (K_0, a) and $(K_0, \theta_{\text{mix}})$, would confirm that water availability and its evacuation act jointly. Any variable with a negligible total index can then be fixed at its mean, reducing the dimensionality of the reliability problem (Section 5.6).

5.6 Reliability analysis

The propagated sample yields the full distribution of the QoI. Reconstructing its PDF and CDF (Figure 5.3) turns the input scatter into a quantitative safety statement: with the limit-state $G = p_{\text{crit}} - p_g^{10}$ and the reliability formulas of Appendix B.5 (Equation (B.19)), the probability of failure is the upper-tail area $P_f = 1 - F_{p_g^{10}}(p_{\text{crit}})$ and the reliability index is $\beta = -\Phi^{-1}(P_f)$, where p_{crit} is the critical pressure tied to the temperature-degraded tensile strength.

Figure 5.3: Reconstructed PDF and CDF of p_g^{10} with the critical threshold p_{crit} ; the shaded upper tail is P_f . The measured Kalifa 10 mm peak is shown for comparison.

[DRAFT]

Analysis. Plotting p_{crit} on the PDF/CDF makes P_f the visible tail beyond it, and placing the Chapter 4 calibrated value on the same axis shows how the uncertainty band straddles the limit state. Because the experimental 10 mm peak of the Kalifa test is available, the reconstructed distribution can be confronted directly with the measurement, giving an experimental anchor for the estimated P_f and β .

5.7 Effect of spatial heterogeneity on structural safety

The analysis above treats each property as a single *random variable*, constant over the specimen in a given realisation. Real concrete varies from point to point, and local weak zones — not average properties — trigger spalling. Two descriptions are therefore compared, both detailed in Appendix B: a *random variable* (homogeneous per realisation), propagated by LHS or, as a cheap deterministic cross-check, by Gaussian quadrature (Appendices B.3 and B.3.4); and a *random field* (correlation length L_c), generated on the Cast3M mesh by the ALEA operator — Turning Bands plus lognormal transform

(Appendices B.2.3 and B.2.4) — and propagated by Monte Carlo through the loop of Appendix B.2.5.

Figure 5.4: CDF of p_g^{10} under the homogeneous (random variable) and heterogeneous (random field, ALEA) descriptions, with the resulting P_f / β .

[DRAFT]

Analysis. Spatial heterogeneity is generally *more critical* than the homogeneous assumption: with a random variable the whole structure shares one value per realisation, so weak zones are compensated by strong ones, whereas with a random field local weak zones can initiate failure without compensation. For the same nominal distributions, the ALEA/Monte Carlo case therefore tends to give a higher P_f (lower β) than the random-variable (quadrature/LHS) case [6, 8]; the gap in Figure 5.4 quantifies how much the homogeneous assumption underestimates the spalling risk for p_g^{10} . The full derivations, the ALEA/Turning-Bands construction and the quadrature operators are collected in Appendix B.

[REVIEW] Old content is below

[DRAFT]

The quadrature method models each uncertain parameter as a single random variable, constant over the entire structure (Appendix B.3). The Monte Carlo framework, on the other hand, models parameters as random fields discretised via the Turning Band Method, allowing spatial variability within each realisation (Appendix B.2).

The key consequence for reliability is that spatial heterogeneity generally leads to *more critical* (conservative) results compared to the homogeneous assumption:

- With random variables (quadrature), the entire structure has the same material property in each realisation — weak zones are compensated by strong zones.
- With random fields (Monte Carlo), local weak zones can form where failure initiates, without being compensated by surrounding material.

This explains why Monte Carlo simulations with spatial variability typically yield higher probabilities of failure (lower β) than the quadrature approach for the same nominal input distributions [6, 8].

Chapter 6

Conclusions and Perspectives

[REVIEW] This chapter is under review and should be limited to 2 pages

6.1 Main findings

- (1) THM model with hydration-degree implemented and runnable in Cast3M;
- (2) temperature calibrated well, matching Kalifa and Dauti;
- (3) gas pressure not calibrated accurately regardless of parameter adjustment $\rightarrow$ raises questions about the nature of the measured quantity;
- (4) sensitivity: indicates the dominant parameter group (via first and second order Sobol);
- (5) reliability: quantifies the risk of spalling from the 10 mm gas pressure layer near the surface;
- (6) spatial heterogeneity (random field) gives unfavorable results compared to the homogeneity assumption.

6.2 Model limitations and possible improvements

The TH $\rightarrow$ M model is one-dimensional (staggered, creep removed);

the random-field ALEA cannot yet be fully integrated into the THM model due to computational cost; gas pressure calibration is still open.

6.3 Perspectives for future research

Notable points include:

- (a) redesigning/re-proposing gas pressure measurements to verify actual measured values;
- (b) full coupling of two-dimensional M→H (damage→permeability);
- (c) integrating random field directly into THM via surrogate/metamodel to reduce Monte Carlo costs;
- (d) extending THC to full service life (curing→aging→accident) as in Sciumè 2024;
- (e) verification on different concrete types/heating scenarios.

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Appendix A

Thermo-Hydro-Mechanical behavior of Heated Concrete

[REVIEW] This chapter is under review

A.1 Thermal behavior

A.1.1 Conduction, convection and radiation

Heat transfer is the transport of thermal energy driven by a temperature difference. The following definitions of heat transfer modes are summarized from standard references [3].

Conduction

Conduction is the transfer of energy from the more energetic to the less energetic particles of a substance **[DRAFT]** due to interactions between the particles.

- **Physical Mechanism:** **[DRAFT]** In a gas, conduction is associated with the net transfer of energy by random molecular motion, often referred to as a diffusion of energy. In a solid, conduction may be attributed to atomic activity in the form of lattice vibrations, and in a conductor, it is also due to the translational motion of the free electrons.
- **Rate Equation (Fourier's Law):** For a one-dimensional plane wall having a temperature distribution $T(x)$, the rate equation is expressed as Fourier's law:

$$q''_{cond} = -\lambda \frac{dT}{dx} \quad (\text{A.1})$$

Where q''_{cond} is the heat flux (W/m^2), λ is the thermal conductivity ($W/m \cdot K$), and the minus sign indicates that heat is transferred in the direction of decreasing temperature.

Convection

The convection heat transfer mode is [DRAFT] comprised of two mechanisms: energy transfer due to random molecular motion (diffusion) and energy transfer by the bulk, or macroscopic, motion of the fluid.

- **Physical Mechanism:** Convection heat transfer occurs between a fluid in motion and a bounding surface when the two are at different temperatures [DRAFT] , which leads to the development of a hydrodynamic (velocity) boundary layer and a thermal boundary layer. [DRAFT]
- **Classification:** Convection is classified as forced convection when the flow is caused by external means (like a fan or pump), or free (natural) convection when the flow is induced by buoyancy forces due to density differences. There are also convection processes accompanied by latent heat exchange, such as boiling and condensation.
- **Rate Equation (Newton's Law of Cooling):** Regardless of the nature of the convection process, the appropriate rate equation is:

$$q''_{conv} = h(T_s - T_\infty) \quad (A.2)$$

Where q'' is the convective heat flux (W/m^2), h is the convection heat transfer coefficient ($W/m^2 \cdot K$), T_s is the surface temperature, and T_∞ is the fluid temperature.

Radiation

Thermal radiation is energy emitted by matter that is at a nonzero temperature, and unlike conduction and convection, it does not require the presence of a material medium.

- **Physical Mechanism:** The energy of the radiation field is transported by electromagnetic waves (or photons) [DRAFT] and may be attributed to changes in the electron configurations of the constituent atoms or molecules.
- **Emissive Power (Stefan-Boltzmann law):** The upper limit to the emissive power (rate of energy released per unit area) for an ideal radiator or blackbody is given:

$$E_b = \sigma T_s^4 \quad (A.3)$$

The heat flux emitted by a real surface is given by $E = \varepsilon\sigma T_s^4$, where σ is the Stefan-Boltzmann constant and ε is the emissivity. **[DRAFT]**

- **Irradiation and Absorption:** The rate at which radiation is incident on a unit area of the surface from its surroundings is called irradiation, G . The rate at which radiant energy is absorbed is given by $G_{abs} = \alpha G$, where α is the absorptivity.
- **Net Radiation Exchange:** For a gray surface **[DRAFT]** ($\alpha = \varepsilon$) at T_s completely surrounded by a much larger isothermal surface at T_{sur} , the net rate of radiation heat transfer per unit area is:

$$q''_{rad} = \varepsilon\sigma(T_s^4 - T_{sur}^4) \quad (\text{A.4})$$

[DRAFT] For many applications, this can also be expressed using a linearized radiation heat transfer coefficient h_r as $q_{rad} = h_r A(T_s - T_{sur})$.

A.1.2 Heat transfer

Heat Equation

Based on the principle of energy conservation and Fourier's law, the general heat diffusion equation (or heat equation) for a medium is detailed in [7] and can be expressed as:

$$\rho c_p \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \text{div}(-\lambda \overrightarrow{\text{grad}}(T)) - q = 0 \quad (\text{A.5})$$

Where:

- ρ is the volumetric mass density (kg/m^3).
- c_p is the specific heat capacity ($J/kg \cdot K$).
- λ is the thermal conductivity ($W/m \cdot K$).
- T is the temperature field and t is time.
- q is the volume heat flux source (W/m^3).

To solve this equation, appropriate boundary conditions must be specified:

- **Prescribed temperatures **[DRAFT]** (Dirichlet condition) :** The temperature is specified as $T = T_{imp}$ on the boundary surface ∂V^T .

- **Prescribed surface heat flux [DRAFT] (Neumann / Mixed condition) :**
The total heat flux due to conduction, convection, and radiation on the boundary surface ∂V^φ is given by:

$$\vec{n} \cdot (\lambda \overrightarrow{\text{grad}}(T)) = \varphi_{imp} + h(T_f - T) + \varepsilon \sigma (T_\infty^4 - T^4) \quad (\text{A.6})$$

where φ_{imp} is the prescribed heat flux, $h(T_f - T)$ represents the convection term, and $\varepsilon \sigma (T_\infty^4 - T^4)$ is the radiation term.

Thermal properties

The thermal properties of concrete are strongly influenced by both the hydric state and the material composition.

The overall heat capacity ρC_p reflects the multiphase nature of the porous medium, combining contributions from the solid skeleton, liquid water, dry air, and water vapor [lewis1998]:

$$\rho C_p = (1 - \phi) \rho_s C_{ps} + \phi [S_l \rho_l C_{pl} + (1 - S_l) (\rho_a C_{pa} + \rho_v C_{pv})] \quad (\text{A.7})$$

where:

The solid density decreases linearly with temperature due to dehydration: $\rho_s(T) = \rho_{s0}[1 - A_\rho(T - T_0)]$ with $\rho_{s0} = 2611 \text{ kg/m}^3$.

The liquid water density evolves with temperature according to a polynomial fit [furbish1997]:

$$\rho_l(T) = \sum_{i=0}^5 a_i T^i \quad (\text{A.8})$$

with coefficients a_i given in Table ??.

[REVIEW] This section is under review for matching the THC model implemented. Cps is not updated The solid thermal capacity evolves linearly with temperature [harmathy1973]:

$$C_{ps}(T) = C_{ps0}[1 + A_c(T - T_0)] \quad (\text{A.9})$$

with $C_{ps0} = 940 \text{ J} \cdot \text{kg}^{-1} \text{K}^{-1}$.

The thermal conductivity depends on saturation, porosity, and temperature [baggio1993]:

$$\lambda = \lambda_d \left(1 + 4 \frac{S_l \phi \rho_l}{(1 - \phi) \rho_s} \right) \quad (\text{A.10})$$

with [harmathy1973]:

$$\lambda_d = \lambda_{d0} [1 + A_\lambda (T - T_0)] \quad (\text{A.11})$$

As drying progresses ($S_l \rightarrow 0$), both ρC_p and λ decrease, which accelerates the penetration of the thermal front into the material. These dependencies highlight the influence of the hydric state on the thermal field, which is further discussed in Appendix A.4.1.

Discretization

[DRAFT] In many practical cases, analytical solutions to the heat equation are impossible to obtain due to complex geometries or boundary conditions. Instead, the problem is approximated using numerical methods, such as the Finite Element (FE) method.

Using the FE discretization, the temperature and temperature gradient in the spatial domain are expressed in matrix form as:

$$T(x) = [N(x)]\{T\}, \quad \overrightarrow{\text{grad}}(T) = [B(x)]\{T\} \quad (\text{A.12})$$

From the weak formulation of the heat equation combined with the spatial discretization, we obtain the general matrix equation:

$$[C]\{\dot{T}\} + [K]\{T\} = \{F\} \quad (\text{A.13})$$

Where the matrices are defined as follows:

- **Capacity matrix:**

$$[C] = \int_V \rho c_p [N]^T [N] dV \quad (J/K) \quad (\text{A.14})$$

- **Conductivity matrix:**

$$[K] = \int_V [B]^T [\lambda] [B] dV + \int_{\partial V_\varphi} h [N]^T [N] dS \quad (W/K) \quad (\text{A.15})$$

- **Equivalent nodal flux vectors:**

$$\{F\} = \int_V [N]^T q dV + \int_{\partial V_\varphi} [N]^T (\varphi_{imp} + hT_f + \varepsilon\sigma(T_\infty^4 - T^4)) dS \quad (W) \quad (\text{A.16})$$

For steady-state thermal analysis, the temperature is time-independent ($\{\dot{T}\} = 0$) **[DRAFT]**. Thus, the system simplifies into a linear algebraic equation (assuming constant material properties and neglecting radiation):

$$[K]\{T\} = \{F\} \quad (\text{A.17})$$

By solving this linear system, we can determine the unknown temperatures $\{T\}$ at the nodes across the entire global mesh.

A.1.3 Thermal gradient

Due to the low thermal conductivity of concrete, fire exposure produces steep temperature gradients near the heated surface. The hot surface layer tends to expand while the cooler interior restrains this deformation, generating compressive stresses at the surface and tensile stresses in the interior.

Since concrete is inherently weak in tension, this stress state can initiate cracking parallel to the heated face. The role of thermal gradient in the spalling process is discussed further in Appendix A.5.2.

A.2 Hydric behavior

[REVIEW] This section is under review for matching the THC model implemented

[REVIEW]

When concrete is exposed to high temperatures, the behavior of water within the porous network plays a central role in the thermo-hydro-mechanical response of the material. This section presents the classification of water in concrete, the phase-change mechanisms, the governing equation for moisture transport, and the constitutive laws required to close the system.

A.2.1 Types of water in concrete

Concrete is a multiphase porous material whose voids can be filled with water, air and other fluids. The water present in the cement paste can be broadly classified into two categories [5]

- **Pore water (free/evaporable water):** This water evaporates when the thermodynamic conditions are met (*i.e.*, at $T = 100^\circ\text{C}$ and atmospheric pressure) and exists in three main forms:
 - *Capillary and inter-hydrate water:* fills the capillary pores (size $\sim 100\text{s}$ of nm) and inter-hydrate pores (size $\sim 10\text{s}$ of nm), corresponding to a saturation $S_{ssp} < S_l < 1$.

- *Physically adsorbed water (gel water)*: retained by the surface of the solid matrix due to Van der Waals forces, confined in gel pores (size $\sim$ a few nm).
- *Interlayer water*: confined in ~ 1 nm space between the C-S-H layers.
- **Chemically bound water (non-evaporable)**: This water is combined with anhydrous cement during hydration and forms part of the crystalline structure of hydration products (e.g., C-S-H, portlandite). It can only be released through thermal decomposition (dehydration) at elevated temperatures.

It is important to note that the range of pore sizes is a continuous one; the dimensional boundaries between capillary, inter-hydrate and gel pores are approximations to inherently blurred boundaries.

A.2.2 Evaporation and dehydration

Two distinct phase-change mechanisms govern the release of water in heated concrete:

- **Evaporation** is the transition of free liquid water into vapor. It occurs progressively as temperature increases, becoming significant above approximately 100°C at atmospheric pressure. The evaporation rate $\dot{m}_{vap}$ is determined from the mass conservation of liquid water (see Appendix A.2.3).
- **Dehydration** is the thermally-driven decomposition of hydration products, releasing chemically bound water as vapor. The main reactions occur at characteristic temperature ranges [5]:
 - Up to 300°C : progressive decomposition of C-S-H phases and ettringite;
 - $400\text{--}500^\circ\text{C}$: dehydroxylation of portlandite ($\text{Ca(OH)}_2 \rightarrow \text{CaO} + \text{H}_2\text{O}$);
 - $\sim 570^\circ\text{C}$: α - β quartz transformation;
 - Above 600°C : decarbonation of calcareous aggregates ($\text{CaCO}_3 \rightarrow \text{CaO} + \text{CO}_2$).

Both evaporation and dehydration act as vapor sources that increase gas pressure within the pore network. They also consume latent energy, affecting the temperature field (see Appendix A.4).

Dehydration kinetics

The cumulative dehydrated water mass is described by the following phenomenological relationship [pesavento2000]:

$$\Delta m_{dehyd} = f_s \cdot f_m \cdot f_c \cdot f(T) \quad (\text{A.18})$$

where f_s is a stoichiometric factor, f_m accounts for the concrete's age, f_c is the cement mass per unit volume, and $f(T)$ is a temperature-dependent function:

$$f(T) = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } T < 105^\circ\text{C} \\ \left[1 + \sin\left(\frac{\pi}{2} (1 - 2 \exp(-0.004 (T - 105)))\right)\right] & \text{if } T \geq 105^\circ\text{C} \end{cases} \quad (\text{A.19})$$

Enthalpy of evaporation

The enthalpy of evaporation is temperature-dependent and is approximated by the Watson formula [reid1987]:

$$\Delta H_{vap}(T) = \Delta H_{vap,0} \left(\frac{T_{crit} - T}{T_{crit} - T_0} \right)^{0.38} \quad (\text{A.20})$$

where $T_{crit} = 647$ K is the critical temperature of water and $\Delta H_{vap,0} = 2.672 \times 10^5$ J/kg.

A.2.3 Moisture transport equation

Transport mechanisms

The transport of moisture in heated concrete is governed by two mechanisms:

- **Advective flow (Darcy's law):** The bulk flow of liquid water and gas through the porous network is driven by pressure gradients:

$$\mathbf{v}_{l-s} = -\frac{K k_{rl}}{\mu_l} (\nabla p_g - \nabla p_c) \quad (\text{A.21})$$

$$\mathbf{v}_{g-s} = -\frac{K k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g \quad (\text{A.22})$$

where K is the intrinsic permeability, k_{rl} and k_{rg} are the relative permeabilities of liquid and gas, μ_l and μ_g are the dynamic viscosities, and $p_l = p_g - p_c$ is the liquid pressure.

- **Diffusive flow (Fick's law):** Water vapor diffuses within the gas mixture according to:

$$\mathbf{j}_v = -\rho_g D \nabla \left(\frac{\rho_v}{\rho_g} \right) \quad (\text{A.23})$$

where D is the effective diffusivity accounting for the tortuous porous network.

Mass conservation equations

The mathematical framework for moisture transport in heated concrete is based on the conservation of mass for each phase. The general form of a mass conservation equation for a phase π is [5]:

$$\frac{\partial}{\partial t} (\text{density}) + \nabla \cdot (\text{flux}) = \text{source} \quad (\text{A.24})$$

Concrete at high temperature is treated as a multiphase porous medium consisting of a solid skeleton (s), liquid water (l), water vapor (v), and dry air (a). Applying Equation (A.24) to each phase yields [5]:

- **Solid skeleton:**

$$\frac{\partial m_s}{\partial t} = \dot{m}_{dehyd} \quad (\text{A.25})$$

- **Liquid water:**

$$\frac{\partial m_l}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot (m_l \mathbf{v}_{l-s}) = -\dot{m}_{vap} - \dot{m}_{dehyd} \quad (\text{A.26})$$

- **Water vapor:**

$$\frac{\partial m_v}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot (m_v \mathbf{v}_{g-s}) + \nabla \cdot (m_v \mathbf{v}_{v-g}) = \dot{m}_{vap} \quad (\text{A.27})$$

- **Dry air:**

$$\frac{\partial m_a}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot (m_a \mathbf{v}_{g-s}) + \nabla \cdot (m_a \mathbf{v}_{a-g}) = 0 \quad (\text{A.28})$$

where $\mathbf{v}_{\pi-s}$ is the velocity of phase π ($\pi = l, g$) relative to the solid skeleton, and $\mathbf{v}_{\pi-g}$ is the velocity of species π ($\pi = v, a$) relative to the gas mixture. The source term $\dot{m}_{vap}$ represents the evaporation rate ($\dot{m}_{vap} > 0$ for evaporation, < 0 for condensation), and $\dot{m}_{dehyd}$ is the dehydration rate ($\dot{m}_{dehyd} < 0$, treated as a mass loss of the solid skeleton and a mass source for liquid water).

The mass of each phase per unit volume of porous medium is [5]:

$$m_s = (1 - \phi) \rho_s \quad (\text{A.29})$$

$$m_l = \rho_l S_l \phi \quad (\text{A.30})$$

$$m_v = \rho_v (1 - S_l) \phi \quad (\text{A.31})$$

$$m_a = \rho_a (1 - S_l) \phi \quad (\text{A.32})$$

where ϕ is the porosity and S_l is the liquid saturation degree.

By combining the mass conservation of liquid water and water vapor, the evaporation

source term $\dot{m}_{vap}$ is eliminated, yielding the **water species conservation equation**:

$$S_l \rho_l \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial t} + S_l \phi \frac{\partial \rho_l}{\partial t} + \rho_l \phi \frac{\partial S_l}{\partial t} + (1 - S_l) \phi \frac{\partial \rho_v}{\partial t} - \rho_v \phi \frac{\partial S_l}{\partial t} + (1 - S_l) \rho_v \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial t} \\ + \nabla \cdot \left(-K \frac{\rho_l k_{rl}}{\mu_l} \nabla p_l \right) + \nabla \cdot \left(-K \frac{\rho_v k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g - D \rho_g \frac{M_v M_a}{M_g^2} \nabla \frac{p_v}{p_g} \right) = -\dot{m}_{dehyd} \quad (\text{A.33})$$

This equation has three primary unknowns: the temperature T , the capillary pressure p_c , and the gas pressure p_g . Similarly, the **dry air conservation equation** reads:

$$(1 - S_l) \phi \frac{\partial \rho_a}{\partial t} - \rho_a \phi \frac{\partial S_l}{\partial t} + (1 - S_l) \rho_a \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial t} + \nabla \cdot \left(-K \frac{\rho_a k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g - D \rho_g \frac{M_v M_a}{M_g^2} \nabla \frac{p_a}{p_g} \right) = 0 \quad (\text{A.34})$$

Constitutive relations for the gas phase

The gaseous phase (dry air + water vapor) is governed by the following relations [5]:

- **Ideal gas law:**

$$\rho_\pi = \frac{p_\pi M_\pi}{RT}, \quad \pi = a, v \quad (\text{A.35})$$

where M_π is the molar mass and R is the universal gas constant.

- **Dalton's law:**

$$p_g = p_a + p_v \quad (\text{A.36})$$

- **Kelvin equation** (thermodynamic equilibrium between liquid and vapor):

$$p_v = p_{vs}(T) \exp \left(\frac{M_v}{\rho_l RT} (p_g - p_c - p_{vs}) \right) \quad (\text{A.37})$$

where $p_{vs}(T)$ is the saturation vapor pressure, approximated by the Hyland-Wexler relationship [ashrae2001]:

$$p_{vs}(T) = \exp \left[\frac{C_1}{T} + C_2 + C_3 T + C_4 T^2 + C_5 T^3 + C_6 \ln(T) \right] \quad (\text{A.38})$$

Sorption isotherms

The relationship between capillary pressure and liquid saturation is described by the Van Genuchten model [vangenuchten1980, baroghel1999]:

$$p_c = a (S_l^{-b} - 1)^{1-1/b} \quad (\text{A.39})$$

where a and b are material parameters determined experimentally. Representative values at ambient temperature are given in Table A.1.

Table A.1: Van Genuchten parameters at ambient temperature

	NSC	HPC	NSM	HPM
a [MPa]	18.62	46.94	37.55	96.28
b [-]	2.275	2.060	2.168	1.954

At elevated temperatures, the parameter a is modified to account for changes in surface tension and pore structure [pesavento2000]:

$$S_l = \left(\left(\frac{E(T)}{a(T)} p_c \right)^{b/(b-1)} + 1 \right)^{-1/b} \quad (\text{A.40})$$

where $E(T)$ accounts for the surface tension evolution and $a(T)$ accounts for microstructure changes above 100 °C.

Intrinsic permeability

Permeability is a key parameter governing moisture transport. For a thermo-hydral problem, the following relationship is adopted [gawin1999]:

$$K = K_0 \cdot 10^{A_T(T-T_0)} \left(\frac{p_g}{p_{atm}} \right)^{A_p} \quad (\text{A.41})$$

where K_0 is the intrinsic permeability at reference conditions, $A_T = 0.005$ and $A_p = 0.368$.

When mechanical damage is considered, the permeability increases significantly [gawin2002]:

$$K = K_0 \cdot 10^{A_T(T-T_0)} \left(\frac{p_g}{p_{atm}} \right)^{A_p} \cdot 10^{A_D \mathcal{D}} \quad (\text{A.42})$$

where $\mathcal{D}$ is the damage parameter and A_D is a material constant. This damage-permeability coupling is a key mechanism in the THM model (see Appendix A.4).

Relative permeability

The relative permeabilities of liquid and gas are described by the Van Genuchten relationships [vanguenuchten1980]:

$$k_{rl} = \sqrt{S_l} \left(1 - \left(1 - S_l^{1/A_S} \right)^{A_S} \right)^2 \quad (\text{A.43})$$

$$k_{rg} = \sqrt{1 - S_l} \left(1 - S_l^{1/A_S} \right)^{2A_S} \quad (\text{A.44})$$

where $A_S = 0.6$.

Effective diffusivity

The diffusivity of vapor in air at a given temperature and pressure is [perre1990]:

$$D_{va}(T, p_g) = D_{v0} \left(\frac{T}{T_0} \right)^{B_v} \frac{p_{g0}}{p_g} \quad (\text{A.45})$$

where $D_{v0} = 2.58 \times 10^{-5} \text{ m}^2/\text{s}$ and $B_v = 1.667$. The effective diffusivity in the porous medium accounts for saturation and tortuosity:

$$D = (1 - S_l)^{A_v} \phi \tau D_{va}(T, p_g) \quad (\text{A.46})$$

with the tortuosity:

$$\tau(\phi, S_l) = \phi^{1/3} (1 - S_l)^{7/3} \quad (\text{A.47})$$

Fluid viscosities

The dynamic viscosities are temperature-dependent [ashrae2001]. The gas viscosity is a concentration-weighted average:

$$\mu_g = \frac{p_v}{p_g} \mu_v + \frac{p_a}{p_g} \mu_a \quad (\text{A.48})$$

where μ_v and μ_a are linear functions of temperature. The liquid water viscosity decreases strongly with temperature [thomas1995]:

$$\mu_l = \mu_{l0} \exp \left(\frac{-\alpha_l (T - T_0)}{T} \right) \quad (\text{A.49})$$

with $\mu_{l0} = 1.002 \times 10^{-3} \text{ Pa}\cdot\text{s}$ and $\alpha_l = 0.6612$.

Porosity evolution

The porosity increases with temperature due to microstructural changes [schneider1989]:

$$\phi = \phi_0 + A_\phi (T - T_0) \quad (\text{A.50})$$

where ϕ_0 is the initial porosity and A_ϕ is a material constant.

A.2.4 Pore pressure build-up

When concrete is heated, evaporation and dehydration produce vapor that raises the pore pressure. Part of this vapor migrates toward the cooler interior, where it recondenses and

forms a quasi-saturated zone — the *moisture clog*. This layer blocks further gas transport, causing significant pressure build-up behind the drying front. In dense concretes such as HPC, the low intrinsic permeability K_0 further limits gas evacuation.

When the pore pressure exceeds the tensile strength, it can trigger explosive spalling (Appendix A.5.2).

A.3 Mechanical behavior

[REVIEW]

The mechanical behaviour is modelled by coupling linear elasticity with continuum damage mechanics (Mazars model), described in the following subsections.

The TH and mechanical problems are solved with a staggered (sequential) solution strategy: the TH subsystem is solved first to obtain p_g , p_c , T , which are then passed as known loading to the mechanical step.

The specific coupling method between the TH and mechanical solvers has not yet been finalized and will be detailed and modified in Chapter 2 and Chapter 3 as the study progresses.

A.3.1 Linear elastic model

In the present work, concrete is modeled as a linear elastic material. The effective stress tensor $\tilde{\sigma}$, defined as the stress acting on the undamaged material, is related to the elastic strain tensor ϵ_e through the isotropic Hooke's law:

$$\sigma = \mathbb{C} : \epsilon_e \quad (\text{A.51})$$

where $\mathbb{C}$ is the constant fourth-order elastic stiffness tensor, defined by the Young's modulus E and Poisson's ratio ν .

The total strain is decomposed into mechanical and free (stress-free) components, as detailed in Appendix A.4.2. Since creep is neglected in this work, the elastic strain reduces to:

$$\epsilon_e = \epsilon - \epsilon_{th} - \epsilon_{sh} \quad (\text{A.52})$$

which enters directly into Hooke's law (Equation (A.51)).

Linear finite element formulation

The spatial discretization of the momentum conservation equation (Equation (A.83)) is carried out using the standard Galerkin finite element method [4].

The continuous displacement field $\mathbf{u}$ is approximated by nodal displacements $\{\mathbf{U}\}$ using shape functions $\mathbf{N}$, and the strain is obtained via the compatibility matrix $\mathbf{B}$ such that $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon} = \mathbf{B}\{\mathbf{U}\}$.

Applying the principle of virtual work, the global system takes the form:

$$[\mathbf{K}_M]\{\mathbf{U}\} = \{\mathbf{F}\} \quad (\text{A.53})$$

where $[\mathbf{K}_M] = \int_V \mathbf{B}^T \mathbb{C} \mathbf{B} dV$ is the elastic stiffness matrix. Its generalisation to account for damage is given in Equation (A.63).

The load vector $\{\mathbf{F}\}$ receives contributions from external forces and from the thermo-hydric fields: (Appendix A.4.1):

$$\{\mathbf{F}\} = \{\mathbf{f}_{ext}\} + \underbrace{\int_V \mathbf{B}^T \mathbb{C} \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}^{th} dV + \int_V \mathbf{B}^T \mathbb{C} \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}^{sh} dV}_{\text{strain decomposition (Equation (A.71))}} + \underbrace{\int_V \mathbf{B}^T \alpha p_s \mathbf{I} dV}_{\text{effective stress (Equation (A.77))}} \quad (\text{A.54})$$

where $\{\mathbf{f}_{ext}\}$ groups the classical external forces. All thermo-hydric terms are computed from the TH solution at each time step and enter as prescribed loading, detailed in Appendix A.4.1.

In Cast3M, this system is assembled using the **RIGI** and **RESO** operators for the linear part. When damage is included, the non-linear iterative solution is handled by **PASAPAS** (Equation (A.64)).

A.3.2 Mazars damage model

Concrete cracks when tensile strains become too large. In this work, this behaviour is represented with the Mazars damage model [mazars1986, 9].

Damage parameter and equivalent strain

The model introduces a single scalar damage variable $\mathcal{D} \in [0, 1]$ [mazars1986]. The effective stress in the damaged material is:

$$\boldsymbol{\sigma}' = (1 - \mathcal{D}) \mathbb{C} \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{el} \quad (\text{A.55})$$

When $\mathcal{D} = 0$, this reduces to Hooke's law (Equation (A.51)). The damage variable is driven by the equivalent strain, computed from the positive principal elastic strains:

[REVIEW]

Because concrete cracking is primarily governed by tensile extensions, Mazars introduced an *equivalent strain* (ε_{eq}) to translate any 3D multiaxial strain state into a scalar uniaxial indicator. In the case of a thermo-mechanical loading, it is important to note that only the elastic strain tensor $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_e$ contributes to the evolution of damage. The equivalent strain is calculated solely from the positive principal elastic strains ε_i :

$$\varepsilon_{eq} = \sqrt{\langle \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_e \rangle_+ : \langle \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_e \rangle_+} = \sqrt{\sum_{i=1}^3 \langle \varepsilon_i \rangle_+^2} \quad (\text{A.56})$$

where the Macaulay brackets $\langle x \rangle_+$ denote the positive part of x (i.e., $\langle x \rangle_+ = x$ if $x \geq 0$, and 0 if $x < 0$).

Damage initiates when the equivalent strain exceeds the initial damage threshold, denoted as ε_{d0} .

$$\varepsilon_{d0} = \frac{f_t}{E}. \quad (\text{A.57})$$

At the damage onset ($\varepsilon_{eq} = \varepsilon_{d0}$), the damage variable is zero:

$$\mathcal{D} = 0 \quad \text{for} \quad \varepsilon_{eq} \leq \varepsilon_{d0}. \quad (\text{A.58})$$

For uniaxial tension, damage onset corresponds to:

$$\sigma_t = f_t. \quad (\text{A.59})$$

In this simplified interpretation, f_t denotes the uniaxial tensile strength of the concrete and E is Young's modulus.

Damage evolution laws for tension and compression

[DRAFT] Concrete exhibits highly asymmetric behavior, characterized by brittle failure in tension and strain-hardening followed by softening in compression. To accurately represent concrete behavior, the total damage D is formulated as a combination of two independent damage variables: D_t for tension and D_c for compression.

When the damage threshold is exceeded ($\varepsilon_{eq} > \varepsilon_{d0}$), the evolution of these two modes is explicitly governed by exponential laws:

$$\mathcal{D}_t = 1 - \frac{(1 - A_t)\varepsilon_{d0}}{\varepsilon_{eq}} - A_t \exp[-B_t(\varepsilon_{eq} - \varepsilon_{d0})] \quad (\text{A.60})$$

$$\mathcal{D}_c = 1 - \frac{(1 - A_c)\varepsilon_{d0}}{\varepsilon_{eq}} - A_c \exp[-B_c(\varepsilon_{eq} - \varepsilon_{d0})] \quad (\text{A.61})$$

where A_t , B_t , A_c , and B_c are material parameters identified from uniaxial tensile and compressive tests. These parameters modulate the shape of the post-peak softening curves: parameters A define the residual asymptotic stress level, while parameters B control the slope of the stress drop.

The global macroscopic damage $\mathcal{D}$ is then calculated using a linear combination with weighting coefficients α_t and α_c :

$$\mathcal{D} = \alpha_t^\beta \mathcal{D}_t + \alpha_c^\beta \mathcal{D}_c \quad (\text{A.62})$$

The coefficients α_t and α_c depend on the principal stress state, evaluating the respective contributions of tensile and compressive stresses. In pure tension, $\alpha_t = 1$ and $\alpha_c = 0$; conversely, in pure compression, $\alpha_c = 1$ and $\alpha_t = 0$. The parameter β (typically fixed at 1.06) is a shear-correction coefficient introduced to improve the structural response under shear loadings.

Non-linear equilibrium and iterative solution

In the general case with damage, the stiffness matrix reads:

$$[\mathbf{K}_M] = \int_V \mathbf{B}^T (1 - \mathcal{D}) \mathbb{C} \mathbf{B} dV \quad (\text{A.63})$$

When $\mathcal{D} = 0$ (intact material), this reduces to the standard linear elastic stiffness matrix $\int_V \mathbf{B}^T \mathbb{C} \mathbf{B} dV$.

Due to damage evolution, the constitutive relation becomes non-linear and Equation (A.53) cannot be solved in a single step. The equilibrium is enforced iteratively using a Newton-Raphson-type algorithm [4]. At each iteration i , the stiffness matrix (Equation (A.63)) is evaluated with the current damage $\mathcal{D}^i$, and the correction is obtained from:

$$[\mathbf{K}_M]^i \{\delta \mathbf{U}\}^{i+1} = \{\mathbf{F}\} - \{\mathbf{R}\}^i \quad (\text{A.64})$$

where:

- $\{\mathbf{R}\}^i = \int_V \mathbf{B}^T \boldsymbol{\sigma}^i dV$ is the internal force vector, with $\boldsymbol{\sigma}^i = (1 - \mathcal{D}^i) \mathbb{C} \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{el}^i$;
- $\{\mathbf{F}\}$ is the external load vector including all thermo-hydric contributions (Equation (A.54)).

The displacements and damage are updated until convergence: $\|\{\mathbf{F}\} - \{\mathbf{R}\}^i\| < \epsilon F_{ref}$. In Cast3M, this iterative procedure is handled by the PASAPAS operator.

A.3.3 Mesh dependency and fracture energy regularization

A well-known drawback of local softening models such as Mazars' is the pathological mesh dependency: softening causes strain localization in a band whose width depends on the element size, leading to vanishing energy dissipation upon mesh refinement [bazant1976].

Two main families of regularization exist in the literature:

- **Nonlocal averaging:** the local equivalent strain ε_{eq} is replaced by a weighted spatial average $\bar{\varepsilon}_{eq}$ over a characteristic volume controlled by an internal length l_c [pijaudier1987, girya2011]. This is the approach adopted by [5].
- **Fracture energy regularization (Hillerborg):** the softening law parameters are adjusted element-by-element so that each element dissipates the same fracture energy G_f per unit crack area, regardless of its size [hillerborg1976]. This is the approach adopted in the present work, as it is simpler to implement in Cast3M and does not require additional nonlocal operators.

Principle of fracture energy regularization

Physically, the fracture energy G_f [hillerborg1976] represents the energy per unit area required to propagate a crack. In the continuum damage framework, cracking is smeared over the element volume. A characteristic length L_e bridges the two descriptions: in Cast3M (using @LONGEF), $L_e = V^{1/D}$ where D is the spatial dimension.

The total dissipated energy per unit crack area is:

$$G_f = G_{elastic} + G_{softening} \quad (\text{A.65})$$

Elastic energy ($G_{elastic}$)

The elastic energy density up to damage onset is:

$$g_{elastic} = \frac{1}{2} f_t \varepsilon_{d0} = \frac{f_t^2}{2E_0} \quad (\text{A.66})$$

so that $G_{elastic} = g_{elastic} L_e = \frac{f_t^2}{2E_0} L_e$, and the energy available for softening is:

$$G_{softening} = G_f - \frac{f_t^2}{2E_0} L_e \quad (\text{A.67})$$

Regularization of B_t

Assuming $A_t \approx 1$ (brittle tension), the post-peak stress simplifies to $\sigma \approx f_t \exp[-B_t(\varepsilon - \varepsilon_{d0})]$, whose integral gives $g_{softening} = f_t/B_t$. Equating $G_{softening} = g_{softening} \cdot L_e$ yields the modified parameter:

$$B_t^{mod} = \frac{f_t L_e}{G_f - \frac{f_t^2}{2E_0} L_e} \quad (\text{A.68})$$

This ensures that every element dissipates exactly G_f regardless of mesh size, making the global response objective with respect to spatial discretization.

A.4 Coupling mechanisms

The thermal, hydric, and mechanical behaviors presented in the previous sections are not independent: they interact through a network of coupling mechanisms. This section identifies and formulates the two main coupling paths that govern the response of concrete exposed to fire.

A.4.1 Thermo-Hydric (TH) coupling mechanisms

The thermal and hydric fields are coupled in both directions: temperature drives phase changes and modifies transport properties, while fluid flow and phase changes affect the energy balance.

Temperature as a driver of hydric phenomena

Temperature enters the hydric conservation equations (Equations (A.33) and (A.34)) through two pathways:

- **Mass source terms:** evaporation and dehydration (Appendix A.2.2) are thermally activated processes that inject vapor into the pore network, appearing as source terms $\dot{m}_{vap}$ and $\dot{m}_{dehyd}$ in the mass balance equations;
- **Transport coefficients:** most constitutive parameters are temperature-dependent — permeability $K(T)$, porosity $\phi(T)$, fluid viscosities $\mu(T)$, saturating vapor pressure $p_{vs}(T)$, and diffusivity $D(T)$ — so the coefficients of the mass conservation equations evolve as the thermal field changes.

Energy conservation equation

The energy conservation equation governs the temperature field within the porous medium. Similar to the heat equation in Appendix A.1.2, it includes a storage term, a conductive flux, and additionally accounts for advective heat transport and phase-change energy terms [5]:

$$\rho C_p \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \underbrace{(m_l C_l \mathbf{v}_{l-s} + m_g C_g \mathbf{v}_{g-s}) \cdot \nabla T}_{\text{advection}} + \nabla \cdot (-\lambda \cdot \nabla T) = \underbrace{-H_{vap} \dot{m}_{vap} + H_{dehyd} \dot{m}_{dehyd}}_{\text{phase-change energy}} \quad (\text{A.69})$$

Compared to the classical heat equation Equation (A.5) $\rho C_p \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} - \nabla \cdot (\lambda \nabla T) = 0$, two additional contributions appear:

- **Advective heat transport:** The bulk flow of liquid water and gas, driven by pressure gradients, transport enthalpy through the material. This term redistributes energy along the flow paths and can be significant when permeability and pressure gradients are large.
- **Phase-change energy (right-hand side):** Concrete does not self-generate heat; these terms represent energy consumed by evaporation ($-H_{vap} \dot{m}_{vap}$, heat sink since $\dot{m}_{vap} > 0$) and dehydration ($+H_{dehyd} \dot{m}_{dehyd}$, also a heat sink since $\dot{m}_{dehyd} < 0$). Both locally slow the temperature rise.

After replacing the mass fluxes by Darcy's law (Equations (A.21) and (A.22)), the energy conservation takes its final coupled form:

$$\rho C_p \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} - K \left(C_l \frac{\rho_l k_{rl}}{\mu_l} (\nabla p_g - \nabla p_c) + C_g \frac{\rho_g k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g \right) \cdot \nabla T - \nabla \cdot (\lambda \cdot \nabla T) = -H_{vap} \dot{m}_{vap} + H_{dehyd} \dot{m}_{dehyd} \quad (\text{A.70})$$

where the overall heat capacity ρC_p (Equation (A.7)) and thermal conductivity λ (Equation (A.10)) are defined in Appendix A.1.2.

Thus, the thermal and hydric fields are *strongly coupled*: temperature modifies the source terms and transport coefficients in the moisture equation, while moisture content and fluid flow modify the heat capacity, conductivity, and introduce latent heat and advection terms in the energy equation.

A.4.2 Thermo-hydric input to the mechanical field

The mechanical behaviour of heated concrete is driven by the thermal and hydric fields. The coupling is *one-way*: the converged TH fields (T, p_g, p_c) serve as prescribed loading to the mechanical problem at each time step. The feedback from mechanics to TH through damage-enhanced permeability is discussed in Appendix A.5.1.

The TH fields enter the mechanical problem through two mechanisms: free strains and pore pressure loading, detailed in the following subsections.

Strain decomposition

When a mechanically loaded concrete element is exposed to high temperature, the total strain is decomposed as a superposition of components of different origins [5]:

$$\boldsymbol{\varepsilon} = \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_\sigma + \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{th} + \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{sh} \quad (\text{A.71})$$

where:

- $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_\sigma$ represents the *mechanical strains* induced by external loading (elastic strain, creep strain, etc.);
- $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{th}$ represents the *thermal dilation strain*, driven by the temperature field;
- $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{sh}$ represents the *capillary shrinkage strain*, driven by the capillary pressure field.

In general, the mechanical strain includes elastic and creep contributions:

$$\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_\sigma = \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{el} + \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{creep} \quad (\text{A.72})$$

Since creep is neglected in this work, $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{creep} = \mathbf{0}$ and thus $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_\sigma = \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{el}$

Thermal dilation

The thermal dilation strain is isotropic and produces a uniform expansion of the material, which is expressed in incremental form as [5]:

$$d\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{th} = \beta_s(T) dT \mathbf{I} \quad (\text{A.73})$$

where $\mathbf{I}$ is the second-order identity tensor and $\beta_s(T)$ is the thermal dilation coefficient, which for concrete can be approximated as a linear function of temperature:

$$\beta_s(T) = A_{B1} (T - T_0) + A_{B0} \quad (\text{A.74})$$

with A_{B0} and A_{B1} being material constants.

Capillary shrinkage

The drying process modifies the pore pressure state, which in turn induces a volumetric deformation of the solid skeleton. The capillary shrinkage strain is expressed as [5]:

$$d\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{sh} = \frac{\alpha}{K_T} \frac{dp_s}{dt} \mathbf{I} \quad (\text{A.75})$$

where α is the Biot coefficient, K_T is the bulk modulus of the drained skeleton, and p_s is the average pore pressure acting on the solid skeleton, defined as:

$$p_s = p_g - S_l p_c = S_g p_g + S_l p_l \quad (\text{A.76})$$

This expression represents the saturation-weighted average of the gas and liquid pressures. Since p_g and p_c are direct outputs of the TH problem, p_s is entirely determined by the TH solution.

Effective stress and pore pressure loading

For a porous medium saturated by multiple fluids, the total stress is decomposed into the part carried by the solid skeleton and the part carried by the pore fluids. Following [Lewis1998, 5], the effective stress is defined as:

$$\boldsymbol{\sigma}' = \boldsymbol{\sigma}^{Total} + \alpha p_s \mathbf{I} \quad (\text{A.77})$$

where $\boldsymbol{\sigma}^{Total}$ is the total stress tensor, α is Biot's coefficient, and p_s is the average pore pressure (Equation (A.76)).

The effective stress $\boldsymbol{\sigma}'$ is the stress that governs the mechanical behaviour of the skeleton. In the finite element implementation, this relation is not applied directly; instead, the pore pressure term αp_s enters the load vector as an external loading (Equation (A.54)), and the effective stress is recovered from the elastic strain after solving for displacements:

$$\boldsymbol{\sigma}' = (1 - \mathcal{D}) \mathbb{C} \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{el} \quad (\text{A.78})$$

where $\boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{el} = \boldsymbol{\varepsilon} - \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{th} - \boldsymbol{\varepsilon}_{sh}$ (Equation (A.52)). This effective stress is the input to the Mazars damage criterion (??). In heated concrete, the build-up of gas pressure (Appendix A.2.4) increases p_s in the load vector, which shifts $\boldsymbol{\sigma}'$ toward tension and promotes damage when f_t is exceeded.

A.5 THM model and spalling

This section assembles the governing equations of the thermo-hydro-mechanical (THM) model from the conservation laws and constitutive relations developed in the previous sections. The coupled system is then used to explain how spalling arises from the interaction between thermal, hydric, and mechanical fields.

A.5.1 Full THM governing formulation

The state of concrete at high temperature is described by four primary variables [5]:

$$\mathcal{U} = \{p_g, p_c, T, \mathbf{u}\} \quad (\text{A.79})$$

where p_g is the gas pressure, p_c is the capillary pressure, T is the temperature, and $\mathbf{u}$ is the displacement vector.

The model consists of four conservation equations, each associated with one primary variable. Their final forms, after substitution of Darcy's law, Fick's law, and the constitutive relations, are as follows.

Dry air conservation

$$\begin{aligned} & \phi(1 - S_l) \left(\frac{\partial \rho_a}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial \rho_a}{\partial p_c} \frac{\partial p_c}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial \rho_a}{\partial p_g} \frac{\partial p_g}{\partial t} \right) + (1 - S_l) \rho_a \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} \\ & - \phi \rho_a \left(\frac{\partial S_l}{\partial p_c} \frac{\partial p_c}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial S_l}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} \right) - \nabla \cdot \left(\frac{K \rho_a k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g \right) - \nabla \cdot \left(D \rho_g \frac{M_v M_a}{M_g^2} \nabla \frac{p_a}{p_g} \right) = 0 \end{aligned} \quad (\text{A.80})$$

Water species conservation

$$\begin{aligned} & (S_l \rho_l - (1 - S_l) \rho_v) \frac{\partial \phi}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + S_l \phi \frac{\partial \rho_l}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \phi (\rho_l - \rho_v) \left(\frac{\partial S_l}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial S_l}{\partial p_c} \frac{\partial p_c}{\partial t} \right) \\ & + (1 - S_l) \phi \left(\frac{\partial \rho_v}{\partial T} \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial \rho_v}{\partial p_c} \frac{\partial p_c}{\partial t} + \frac{\partial \rho_v}{\partial p_g} \frac{\partial p_g}{\partial t} \right) \\ & - \nabla \cdot \left(\frac{K \rho_l k_{rl}}{\mu_l} (\nabla p_g - \nabla p_c) \right) - \nabla \cdot \left(\frac{K \rho_v k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g \right) - \nabla \cdot \left(D \rho_g \frac{M_v M_a}{M_g^2} \nabla \frac{p_v}{p_g} \right) = -\dot{m}_{dehyd} \end{aligned} \quad (\text{A.81})$$

Energy conservation

$$\begin{aligned} \rho C_p \frac{\partial T}{\partial t} - K \left(C_l \frac{\rho_l k_{rl}}{\mu_l} (\nabla p_g - \nabla p_c) + C_g \frac{\rho_v k_{rg}}{\mu_g} \nabla p_g \right) \cdot \nabla T - \nabla \cdot (\lambda \cdot \nabla T) \\ = -H_{vap} \dot{m}_{vap} + H_{dehyd} \dot{m}_{dehyd} \end{aligned} \quad (\text{A.82})$$

Momentum conservation

By neglecting inertial forces:

$$\nabla \cdot \boldsymbol{\sigma}^{Total} + \rho \mathbf{g} = \mathbf{0} \quad (\text{A.83})$$

where $\mathbf{g}$ is the gravitational acceleration and the total density is:

$$\rho = (1 - \phi) \rho_s + \phi (S_l \rho_l + (1 - S_l) \rho_g) \quad (\text{A.84})$$

The total stress $\boldsymbol{\sigma}^{Total}$ is related to the effective stress via Bishop's relation (Equation (A.77)), which in turn depends on the primary variables p_g and p_c .

The discretisation of this equation into the global system $[\mathbf{K}_M]\{\mathbf{U}\} = \{\mathbf{F}\}$ is presented in Appendix A.3.

Remark: The governing equations presented in this chapter — dry air conservation, water species conservation, energy conservation, and momentum conservation — together with the constitutive laws, form a complete THM model for concrete exposed to fire. These equations are continuous partial differential equations defined on the domain Ω . Their numerical solution requires spatial and temporal discretization, which is the subject of the following Chapter 3.

A.5.2 Spalling mechanisms

Spalling is defined as the violent or non-violent detachment of layers or pieces of concrete from the surface of a structural element during or after exposure to rapidly rising temperatures. It may lead to premature structural failure through reinforcement exposure and cross-section reduction. Several catastrophic tunnel fires (Channel Tunnel 1996, Mont-Blanc 1999, St. Gotthard 2001) have illustrated the severity of this phenomenon [5].

Despite extensive experimental research, the mechanisms behind spalling are not yet fully understood and no general consensus on a single theory has been reached. The two principal mechanisms most broadly accepted are presented below, followed by their combined action.

Thermal gradient mechanism

[REVIEW] This section is currently under development and will be refined as the study progresses.

When one face of a concrete member is exposed to fire, a steep temperature gradient develops through the thickness. The resulting differential thermal dilation produces (see Figure ??):

1. **Compressive stresses in the heated cover:** The surface layers tend to expand but are restrained by the cooler interior, generating significant compressive stresses parallel to the heated surface.
2. **Tensile stresses in the interior:** The restraint of the expanding surface layers induces tensile stresses in deeper layers of the material.
3. **Fracture and energy release:** When the tensile stress exceeds the tensile strength f_t , cracks develop parallel to the surface. The sudden release of elastic energy stored in the compressed surface layers can drive the explosive ejection of concrete fragments.

High-performance concrete (HPC) is particularly prone to this mechanism due to its higher brittleness: more elastic energy is stored before failure, leading to a more violent release.

Pore pressure mechanism (moisture clog)

[REVIEW] This section is currently under development and will be refined as the study progresses.

The sequence of events is (see Figure ??):

1. **Formation of a dry zone:** As the surface is heated, free water evaporates and chemically bound water is released as vapor through dehydration. A dry zone forms near the heated face.
2. **Vapor migration:** Due to pressure gradients, part of the vapor is evacuated toward the heated face, while part is driven toward the cooler interior.
3. **Condensation and moisture clog:** The inward-migrating vapor condenses when it reaches regions where the thermodynamic conditions are satisfied ($T < T_{sat}$). This process continues until a quasi-saturated zone is formed, known as the *moisture clog*, which acts as an impermeable barrier preventing further vapor migration toward the cold side.

4. **Pressure build-up:** Behind the moisture clog, the gas pressure p_g increases sharply as continued evaporation feeds vapor into a region from which it cannot escape. In addition, the thermal dilation of liquid water in saturated pores also contributes to pressure build-up.
5. **Tensile failure:** When the pore pressure exceeds the tensile strength of the material, cracks develop parallel to the surface, potentially leading to explosive spalling.

The key material parameters governing this mechanism are the *intrinsic permeability* K_0 and the *initial moisture content*. Low permeability hinders vapor evacuation, while high moisture content provides more water to be evaporated, both promoting higher pore pressures.

Combined mechanism

[REVIEW] This section is currently under development and will be refined as the study progresses.

In practice, explosive spalling generally occurs under the *combined action* of pore pressures and thermal stresses. The spalling condition can be expressed schematically as:

$$\sigma_{thermal}(T) + \sigma_{pore}(p_g, p_c, S_l) \geq f_t(T) \quad (\text{A.85})$$

where $\sigma_{thermal}$ represents the thermal stress from differential dilation, σ_{pore} represents the stress from pore pressure loading (via effective stress), and $f_t(T)$ is the temperature-degraded tensile strength. When the sum of stresses exceeds the tensile strength, cracks develop parallel to the heated surface, often leading to violent failure of the fire-exposed region.

This combined criterion highlights why the complete THM model is needed: neither a purely thermal analysis (T only) nor a purely hydal analysis (p_g, p_c only) can capture the full picture.

A.6 Discretization

A.6.1 Spatial discretization

[REVIEW]

The specific coupling method mentioned in Appendix A.3 between the TH and mechanical solvers has not yet been finalized and will be updated in Chapter 2 and Chapter 3 as the study progresses.

Applying the standard Galerkin finite element method to the three TH conservation equations (Equations (A.80) to (A.82)) yields the semi-discrete system [5]:

$$\mathbf{C} \dot{\mathbf{Y}} + \mathbf{K} \mathbf{Y} = \mathbf{f} \quad (\text{A.86})$$

where $\mathbf{Y} = \{\bar{p}_g, \bar{p}_c, \bar{T}\}$ is the vector of nodal TH unknowns. The operators $\mathbf{C}$ (capacity), $\mathbf{K}$ (conductivity), and $\mathbf{f}$ (forcing) are 3×3 block matrices:

$$\mathbf{K} = \begin{pmatrix} K_{gg} & K_{gc} & K_{gt} \\ K_{cg} & K_{cc} & K_{ct} \\ K_{tg} & K_{tc} & K_{tt} \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{C} = \begin{pmatrix} C_{gg} & C_{gc} & C_{gt} \\ 0 & C_{cc} & C_{ct} \\ 0 & C_{tc} & C_{tt} \end{pmatrix}, \quad \mathbf{f} = \begin{pmatrix} f_g \\ f_c \\ f_t \end{pmatrix} \quad (\text{A.87})$$

The off-diagonal entries K_{ij} , C_{ij} ($i \neq j$) encode the coupling between the thermal and hydric fields. Detailed expressions of each block are given in [5], Appendix A.

The mechanical problem (Equation (A.83)) is solved in a staggered manner: at each time step, the converged TH fields $\bar{T}$, $\bar{p}_g$, $\bar{p}_c$ enter as prescribed loading. The discrete equilibrium (Equation (A.53)) reads:

$$[\mathbf{K}_M]\{\mathbf{U}\} = \{\mathbf{F}\} \quad (\text{A.88})$$

where $\mathbf{K}_M$ (Equation (A.63)) contains the damaged stiffness $(1 - \mathcal{D}) \mathbb{C}$ — the displacement-dependent part that remains on the left-hand side — and $\mathbf{F}$ (Equation (A.54)) collects the TH-prescribed loads $(\epsilon^{th}, \epsilon^{sh}, \alpha p_s)$ that do not depend on $\mathbf{U}$.

A.6.2 Temporal discretization

[REVIEW] This section is currently under development and will be refined as the study progresses.

The time integration of Equation (A.86) is carried out using the Wilson- θ method [Lewis1998, zienkiewicz2013], which evaluates the equation at an intermediate time $t_{n+\theta} = t_n + \theta \Delta t$ with $\theta \in [0, 1]$. This transforms the semi-discrete system into a fully discrete algebraic

system at each time step:

$$\tilde{\mathbf{K}} \Delta \mathbf{Y}^{n+1} + \mathbf{K} \mathbf{Y}^n = \mathbf{f}^{n+\theta} \quad (\text{A.89})$$

where:

$$\Delta \mathbf{Y}^{n+1} = \mathbf{Y}^{n+1} - \mathbf{Y}^n, \quad \tilde{\mathbf{K}} = \frac{\mathbf{C}}{\Delta t} + \theta \mathbf{K} \quad (\text{A.90})$$

The parameter θ controls the scheme: $\theta = 0$ gives the explicit forward Euler method, $\theta = 1$ the fully implicit backward Euler, and $\theta = 0.5$ the Crank-Nicolson scheme. In practice, $\theta = 1$ is used for unconditional stability.

Since the capacity and conductivity matrices depend nonlinearly on the unknowns ($\mathbf{C} = \mathbf{C}(\mathbf{Y})$, $\mathbf{K} = \mathbf{K}(\mathbf{Y})$), Equation (A.89) is solved iteratively using the Newton-Raphson method within each time step.

A.6.3 Solution strategy

[REVIEW] This section is currently under development and will be refined as the study progresses.

The TH subsystem (Equation (A.89)) is solved *monolithically*: all three unknowns p_g , p_c , T are updated simultaneously within a single Newton-Raphson loop at each time step.

The mechanical problem (Equation (A.88)) is solved in a *staggered* manner: at each time step, the converged TH solution provides $\bar{T}$, $\bar{p}_g$, $\bar{p}_c$, which are used to assemble $\mathbf{F}$ (Equation (A.54)) and solve for $\mathbf{U}$. The damage variable $\mathcal{D}$ computed from the Mazars model feeds back to the intrinsic permeability via Equation (A.42), creating a weak M→H coupling updated at the next time step.

Appendix B

Additional Results of Stochastic analysis

[REVIEW] This chapter is under review

B.1 Random variable and random field

B.1.1 Random variables (PDF, CDF, moments, CoV)

[REVIEW] This section is currently under development and will be refined as the study progresses.

A **random variable** X is a quantity whose value is not fixed but described by a probability law. Instead of saying “ $E = 30$ GPa”, one writes $E \sim \mathcal{N}(30, 3^2)$ GPa, meaning that the Young’s modulus follows a normal (Gaussian) distribution with mean $\mu = 30$ GPa and standard deviation $\sigma = 3$ GPa.

PDF and CDF

The Probability Density Function (**PDF**) $f_X(x)$ describes the relative likelihood of X taking a given value. It is always non-negative and integrates to one over the entire domain.

The Cumulative Distribution Function (**CDF**) $F_X(x) = P(X \leq x)$ gives the probability that X does not exceed a threshold x :

$$F_X(x) = \int_{-\infty}^x f_X(t) dt. \quad (\text{B.1})$$

In reliability analysis, the CDF is used directly to evaluate the probability of exceeding a critical value: $P(X > x_{\text{cr}}) = 1 - F_X(x_{\text{cr}})$ [2].

Two distributions are used in this work:

- **Normal** (Gaussian) distribution $\mathcal{N}(\mu, \sigma^2)$:

$$f_X(x) = \frac{1}{\sigma\sqrt{2\pi}} \exp\left[-\frac{(x - \mu)^2}{2\sigma^2}\right]. \quad (\text{B.2})$$

- **Lognormal** distribution $\text{LN}(\mu_{\ln}, \sigma_{\ln}^2)$, where $\ln X$ is normally distributed, ensuring $X > 0$:

$$f_X(x) = \frac{1}{x \sigma_{\ln} \sqrt{2\pi}} \exp\left[-\frac{(\ln x - \mu_{\ln})^2}{2\sigma_{\ln}^2}\right], \quad x > 0. \quad (\text{B.3})$$

The lognormal distribution is particularly relevant for material properties such as the Young modulus or permeability, which must remain strictly positive [6, 16, 1].

Statistical moments

The distribution of X can be summarised by its **statistical moments** [2], which quantify location, spread, asymmetry, and tail heaviness. In this work, the first two moments are prescribed as *input* to the stochastic analysis, while the higher moments are *computed as output* by the quadrature method (Appendix B.3).

Input moments. The **mean** μ_X and **variance** σ_X^2 (or equivalently the standard deviation $\sigma_X = \sqrt{\text{Var}[X]}$) define the centre and spread of the distribution:

$$\mu_X = \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} x f_X(x) dx, \quad \sigma_X^2 = \int_{-\infty}^{+\infty} (x - \mu_X)^2 f_X(x) dx. \quad (\text{B.4})$$

Output moments. The **skewness** δ_3 and **kurtosis** δ_4 measure the asymmetry and tail heaviness of the response distribution:

$$\delta_3 = \frac{E[(X - \mu_X)^3]}{\sigma_X^3}, \quad \delta_4 = \frac{E[(X - \mu_X)^4]}{\sigma_X^4}. \quad (\text{B.5})$$

These four moments play a central role in the Gaussian Quadrature method (Appendix B.3), where the response PDF is reconstructed from the computed moments using Winterstein or Pearson approximations [15].

Coefficient of Variation (CoV)

The coefficient of variation quantifies the relative dispersion of X :

$$\text{CoV}_X = \frac{\sigma_X}{\mu_X}. \quad (\text{B.6})$$

It is a dimensionless measure that allows comparison of variability across parameters with different units and magnitudes. For concrete, typical values are $\text{CoV}_E \approx 0.10\text{--}0.20$ for the Young's modulus [6] and $\text{CoV}_K \approx 0.15\text{--}0.30$ for permeability [1].

B.1.2 Random fields and correlation structure

[REVIEW] This section is currently under development and will be refined as the study progresses.

Random fields

A random variable assigns a *single* uncertain value to a material property for the entire structure. In reality, concrete properties vary spatially due to heterogeneous microstructure, local variations in the water-to-cement ratio, and non-uniform compaction during casting [6]. A **random field** captures this spatial variability: it assigns an uncertain value to *every point* $\mathbf{x}$ in the domain, not just one value for the whole structure.

Formally, a random field is a collection of random variables indexed by position [16]:

$$H = \{H(\mathbf{x}, \omega) : \mathbf{x} \in \mathcal{D}, \omega \in \Omega\}, \quad (\text{B.7})$$

where ω denotes one particular realisation drawn from the probability space. For a fixed ω , $H(\cdot, \omega)$ is a deterministic spatial function (one “map” of the property over the structure); for a fixed $\mathbf{x}$, $H(\mathbf{x}, \cdot)$ is an ordinary random variable.

A **second-order** random field is fully characterised by two functions [16]:

- the **mean field** $\bar{H}(\mathbf{x}) = E[H(\mathbf{x})]$,
- the **covariance function** $C_H(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y}) = E[(H(\mathbf{x}) - \bar{H}(\mathbf{x}))(H(\mathbf{y}) - \bar{H}(\mathbf{y}))]$.

The mean field gives the average value at each point; the covariance function measures how strongly the values at two points $\mathbf{x}$ and $\mathbf{y}$ are linked. When both depend only on the separation $\boldsymbol{\tau} = \mathbf{x} - \mathbf{y}$, the field is called **homogeneous** (stationary).

Correlation function and correlation length

When a material property (e.g. Young's modulus) is modelled as a random field, nearby points tend to have similar values while distant points are more different. The **autocorrelation function** $\rho_H(\boldsymbol{\tau})$ quantifies this similarity as a function of distance $\boldsymbol{\tau}$:

$$\rho_H(\boldsymbol{\tau}) = \frac{C_H(\boldsymbol{\tau})}{\sigma_H^2}, \quad \rho_H(\mathbf{0}) = 1, \quad (\text{B.8})$$

where $\sigma_H^2 = C_H(\mathbf{0})$ is the field variance. $\rho = 1$ means two points have identical values; $\rho \approx 0$ means they are nearly independent.

The rate at which ρ decays is controlled by the **correlation length** $L_c > 0$. Two common models for concrete [16, 8]:

$$\rho_H(\tau) = \exp\left(-\frac{\tau^2}{L_c^2}\right) \text{ (squared-exponential),} \quad \rho_H(\tau) = \exp\left(-\frac{|\tau|}{L_c}\right) \text{ (exponential).} \quad (\text{B.9})$$

Physically, L_c represents the distance beyond which material properties become essentially independent. A small L_c means the material varies rapidly in space (highly heterogeneous); a large L_c means properties change slowly (nearly uniform). This effect is illustrated in ??.

Remark: In this work, L_c is not treated as a parameter to be varied. A single representative value is adopted from experimental data [6] to account for spatial heterogeneity in the Monte Carlo simulations (??). The objective is not to study the effect of L_c itself, but to compare the structural response *with* and *without* spatial variability.

B.1.3 Random field simulation

To use a random field in a finite element model, one must *generate* realisations that respect the prescribed covariance structure, then *assign* the values to elements or integration points. Several families of methods exist [8]:

- **Matrix decomposition (Cholesky).** The covariance matrix $\mathbf{C}$ is factorised as $\mathbf{C} = \mathbf{L}\mathbf{L}^T$ and a correlated realisation is obtained as $\mathbf{h} = \mathbf{L}\mathbf{z}$, where $\mathbf{z}$ is a vector of independent standard normal variates [8]. The method is exact but scales as $\mathcal{O}(n^3)$ in the number of nodes n , making it prohibitive for large meshes.

- **Spectral methods (FFT-based).** Realisations are generated by filtering white noise in the frequency domain using the spectral density corresponding to the target covariance [8]. FFT algorithms are computationally efficient on regular grids, but the method is limited to stationary fields on rectangular domains with periodic boundary conditions.
- **Local Average Subdivision (LAS).** LAS generates the random field by successively subdividing the domain and assigning local averages consistent with the target covariance at each level of refinement [8]. The method is computationally efficient and naturally produces spatially averaged values over elements, making it well-suited for direct use in finite element models. However, it is primarily designed for regular rectangular grids.
- **Series expansion methods.** Methods such as the Karhunen–Loève (KL) expansion parametrise the random field as a finite series of deterministic spatial functions multiplied by independent random variables [16, 6]. They provide a compact representation of the spatial variability but require solving a global eigenvalue problem on the finite element mesh, whose cost increases with mesh size and targeted accuracy.
- **Turning Bands Method (TBM).** The TBM reduces the d -dimensional simulation to a set of one-dimensional stationary processes along random lines (bands) passing through the domain [12, 8]. It requires neither a global matrix factorisation nor an eigenvalue solve, and operates directly on any mesh geometry.

In this work, the TBM method, described in detail in Appendix B.2.4, is adopted because it is the method implemented in the Cast3M ALEA operator.

B.1.4 Summary: random variable versus random field

[REVIEW] This section is under review Table B.1 summarises the key differences between the two levels of stochastic description and their implications for the numerical methods used in this work.

Table B.1: Comparison of random variable and random field stochastic descriptions.

Aspect	Random variable	Random field
Spatial variation	None (uniform)	Yes (spatially heterogeneous)
Characterisation	PDF: mean μ , std σ	Mean field $\bar{H}(\mathbf{x})$, covariance $C_H(\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{y})$
Key parameter	CoV	Correlation length L_c
Stochastic level	First-order	Second-order
Simulation method	Gaussian Quadrature	TBM + Monte Carlo
Cast3M operator	QUADRATU	ALEA
Computational cost	Low (3–7 runs per variable)	High (hundreds to thousands of runs)

B.2 Monte Carlo simulation framework

B.2.1 Principle

Monte Carlo simulation (MCS) estimates the effect of uncertain inputs by running the same deterministic model many times, each time with a different random sample [8]. Each trial consists of three steps:

1. Generate a realisation of the random input (random variable or random field) according to its prescribed distribution.
2. Run the deterministic model (here, the THM finite element solver in Cast3M) to obtain the response.
3. Collect the result; repeat until the output statistics are stable.

Because no assumption is made on the shape of the response, MCS can estimate the *entire* output distribution—unlike linearisation methods such as FORM/SORM [8].

B.2.2 Convergence

The probability of failure is estimated as the fraction of realisations where the limit state is violated:

$$\hat{P}_f = \frac{N_f}{n}, \quad (\text{B.10})$$

where the hat denotes that $\hat{P}_f$ is an estimate of the true P_f , which improves as n increases, and N_f is the number of failures out of n total runs. The more runs, the more accurate the estimate—but the error only decreases as $1/\sqrt{n}$. To halve the error, one must quadruple the number of runs.

At 95% confidence, the required number of runs is [8]:

$$n \geq \frac{4p_f(1-p_f)}{e^2}, \quad (\text{B.11})$$

where e is the acceptable absolute error. For a small failure probability ($p_f \approx 10^{-3}$) with 10% relative accuracy, this gives $n \approx 400,000$ runs. When a single THM analysis takes several minutes, this cost becomes prohibitive—motivating the Gaussian Quadrature method (Appendix B.3) as a faster alternative.

B.2.3 Transformation of Lognormal to Gaussian distribution

In practical finite element implementations using the Cast3M software, material parameters such as Young's modulus and permeability must remain strictly positive. However, the built-in random field operator ALEA generates Gaussian (normal) distributions, necessitating a mathematical transformation [16].

A **lognormal random field** $H(\mathbf{x})$ is therefore adopted: by definition, $\ln H(\mathbf{x})$ is a Gaussian random field, which guarantees $H(\mathbf{x}) > 0$ at every point [6]. The moments of $H(\mathbf{x})$ are related to those of the underlying Gaussian field $G(\mathbf{x}) \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_{\ln}, \sigma_{\ln}^2)$ by [16]:

$$\begin{cases} \mu_X = \exp\left(\mu_{\ln} + \frac{\sigma_{\ln}^2}{2}\right) \\ \sigma_X^2 = [\exp(\sigma_{\ln}^2) - 1] \exp(2\mu_{\ln} + \sigma_{\ln}^2) \end{cases} \quad (\text{B.12})$$

where μ_X and σ_X are the physical mean and standard deviation of the material property. Inverting Equation (B.12) yields the Gaussian parameters as functions of the physical moments:

$$\sigma_{\ln}^2 = \ln(1 + CoV_X^2), \quad \mu_{\ln} = \ln(\mu_X) - \frac{1}{2} \sigma_{\ln}^2, \quad (\text{B.13})$$

where $CoV_X = \sigma_X / \mu_X$ is the coefficient of variation.

The standard computational procedure in Cast3M ALEA then consists of two steps:

1. Generate a Gaussian random field $G(\mathbf{x}) \sim \mathcal{N}(\mu_{\ln}, \sigma_{\ln}^2)$ using the Turning Band Method (see Appendix B.2.4), with parameters computed from Equation (B.13).
2. Transform pointwise to obtain the lognormal field:

$$H(\mathbf{x}) = \exp(G(\mathbf{x})), \quad (\text{B.14})$$

which guarantees $H(\mathbf{x}) > 0$ and preserves the correlation structure characterised by L_c (see Appendix B.1.2).

This pointwise transformation is exact: the autocorrelation structure of the underlying Gaussian field is preserved in the lognormal field, so the spatial variability characterised by the correlation length L_c remains physically meaningful after transformation [6].

B.2.4 Turning Bands Method (ALEA)

Principle The Turning Bands Method (TBM), introduced by [12], simplifies the generation of a 2-D or 3-D random field by reducing it to a set of 1-D problems.

The idea (??): draw L lines through the domain in different directions. Along each line, simulate an independent 1-D random process. To obtain the field value at any point $\mathbf{x}$, project it onto each line and average the results:

$$Z(\mathbf{x}) = \frac{1}{\sqrt{L}} \sum_{i=1}^L Z_i(\mathbf{x} \cdot \mathbf{u}_i), \quad (\text{B.15})$$

where $\mathbf{u}_i$ is the direction of the i -th line and Z_i is the 1-D process along it. The 1-D processes are constructed so that the resulting field reproduces the prescribed covariance structure (Appendix B.1.2). In practice, $L = 16$ lines are sufficient for isotropic fields in two dimensions [8].

Implementation in Cast3M The TBM is natively implemented in the Cast3M ALEA operator, which takes as input the Gaussian parameters $(\mu_{\ln}, \sigma_{\ln})$ and the correlation length L_c , and returns the simulated field directly as nodal values on the mesh. The lognormal transformation and assignment to MATE follow the procedure described in Appendix B.2.3.

B.2.5 Integration of spatial variability into the THM model

This section is currently under development and will be refined as the study progresses.

Once the lognormal random field $H(\mathbf{x})$ has been constructed via the Turning Band Method (see Appendix B.2.4), it is propagated through the nonlinear THM model using Monte Carlo simulation. Given the computational cost of each THM evaluation, the iterative procedure is fully automated in Cast3M using the REPETER operator.

Simulation loop and dynamic material updating

For a predefined number of simulations N_{simu} , the global algorithm performs the following sequential steps within each loop:

1. **Random Field Generation:** A new statistically independent realization of the random field is generated using the ALEA operator. For instance, the spatial distribu-

tion of the Young's modulus $\mathbf{E}(x)$ is recalculated based on the assigned log-normal parameters (mean, standard deviation, and correlation length).

2. **Material Updating:** The macroscopic properties of the finite element model are updated. The newly generated random field is projected onto the mesh to form the updated material stiffness matrix using the MATE operator.
3. **Non-linear Resolution:** The PASAPAS procedure is invoked to solve the multi-physics THM problem from $t = 0$ to the final time t_{fin} , utilizing the updated heterogeneous material properties.

[DRAFT]

Data extraction and post-processing

Storing the complete output database (which includes nodal displacements, stress tensors, and internal damage variables for every time step) for hundreds of simulations would result in an unmanageable amount of data and exceed memory limits. Therefore, a selective data extraction strategy is implemented.

Instead of saving the entire mesh history, a specific "Quantity of Interest" (QoI) is dynamically extracted at the end of each calculation loop. Depending on the targeted sensitivity analysis for the spalling risk, the QoI could be the maximum equivalent plastic strain, the peak pore pressure, or the maximum macroscopic damage variable D .

In the Cast3M script, this is executed using the EXCO (to extract the specific component, e.g., the internal variable 'V1' for damage) and MAXI operators to find the extreme value over the spatial domain. Finally, the extracted scalar values are continuously appended to an external structured text file (CSV format) using the SORT 'CHAI' command.

This exported dataset containing the input realizations and the corresponding QoI outputs serves as the direct input for the external probabilistic software (e.g., Persalys) to compute the probability density functions and rank the dominant parameters via Sobol indices Appendix B.4.2.

B.3 Gaussian Quadrature framework

Unlike Monte Carlo, which runs thousands of simulations, Gaussian Quadrature evaluates the model at a small number of strategically chosen points and reconstructs the output statistics from a weighted sum [baldeweck1999, 15]. The method has three steps, corresponding to three Cast3M operators:

1. QUADRATU: compute the evaluation points and weights for each random variable.
2. PARASTAT: run the model at each point combination and compute the first four statistical moments (mean, standard deviation, skewness, kurtosis).
3. PROBDENS: reconstruct the PDF from these moments and estimate P_f and β .

B.3.1 Step 1: Quadrature points and weights (QUADRATU)

Computing any statistical moment of the output $G = g(\mathbf{X})$ requires evaluating an integral:

$$I = \int_{\mathcal{D}} g(x) W(x) dx, \quad (\text{B.16})$$

where $W(x) = f_X(x)$ is the PDF of the input variable. Gaussian quadrature approximates this by a weighted sum over K evaluation points [baldeweck1999]:

$$I \approx \sum_{k=1}^K w_k g(x_k), \quad (\text{B.17})$$

where $\{x_k\}$ are the *abscissas* (evaluation points) and $\{w_k\}$ the corresponding *weights*. The optimal abscissas are the roots of orthogonal polynomials associated with W , and a K -point scheme integrates exactly any polynomial of degree up to $2K - 1$ [15].

QUADRATU automatically computes $\{x_k, w_k\}$ for any prescribed distribution (Normal, Log-normal, Uniform, etc.). The user provides only the distribution type and its parameters.

B.3.2 Step 2: Statistical moments (PARASTAT)

For N independent random variables with K points each, the quadrature is applied to each variable separately and combined as a tensor product [15]:

$$\mu_q^{(0)} \approx \sum_{k_1=1}^{K_1} \cdots \sum_{k_N=1}^{K_N} w_{k_1} \cdots w_{k_N} [g(x_{k_1}, \dots, x_{k_N})]^q, \quad (\text{B.18})$$

requiring K^N model evaluations in total. For example, with $N = 2$ variables and $K = 3$ points each: $3^2 = 9$ runs.

PARASTAT collects these evaluations and returns the first four moments: mean μ , standard deviation σ , skewness $\delta_3 = \mu_3/\sigma^3$, and kurtosis $\delta_4 = \mu_4/\sigma^4$.

B.3.3 Step 3: PDF reconstruction and reliability (PROBDENS)

Once the four moments are known, PROBDENS reconstructs the PDF using *three independent methods simultaneously* [15]:

- **Winterstein approximation:** expresses G as a Hermite polynomial transformation of a standard normal variable. Simplest but least accurate of the three methods.
- **Pearson’s method:** selects the best-fit distribution family (normal, beta, gamma, etc.) from the moment values. Most accurate, but does not always provide a result.
- **Exponential of polynomials ($n = 4$):** models the PDF as $\tilde{f}_G = c \exp(Q)$ where Q is a polynomial fitted to the moments. Always provides accurate results.

Each method independently yields a probability of failure P_f and reliability index β . When the three results are consistent with each other, they can be accepted with confidence [15]:

$$P_f = \tilde{F}_G(0), \quad \beta = -\Phi^{-1}(P_f), \quad (\text{B.19})$$

where $\tilde{F}_G$ is the reconstructed CDF and Φ^{-1} the inverse standard normal CDF. The method provides accurate results for $\beta \lesssim 5$ [15].

B.3.4 Computational cost

The total number of model evaluations is K^N , which grows exponentially with N . For the present study with $N = 2$ and $K = 3$, this gives only 9 runs—compared to thousands for Monte Carlo. However, for large N (e.g. $3^{10} = 59,049$ runs), the cost becomes comparable to Monte Carlo. This *curse of dimensionality* limits the method to problems with a small number of random variables ($N \lesssim 10\text{--}15$) [15].

B.4 Sensitivity indicators and ranking methods

B.4.1 Variance decomposition

For a model $G = g(X_1, \dots, X_N)$ with N independent random inputs, Hoeffding’s decomposition [sobol1993] expresses G as a sum of functions of increasing dimension:

$$G = g_0 + \sum_{i=1}^N g_i(X_i) + \sum_{i < j} g_{ij}(X_i, X_j) + \dots + g_{1,\dots,N}(X_1, \dots, X_N), \quad (\text{B.20})$$

where $g_0 = \mathbb{E}[G]$ is a constant and each term has zero mean. Taking the variance of both sides yields:

$$\text{Var}(G) = \sum_{i=1}^N V_i + \sum_{i < j} V_{ij} + \cdots + V_{1,\dots,N}, \quad (\text{B.21})$$

where $V_i = \text{Var}[g_i(X_i)]$ is the first-order variance (effect of X_i alone) and $V_{ij} = \text{Var}[g_{ij}(X_i, X_j)]$ is the second-order variance (interaction between X_i and X_j).

B.4.2 Variance-based sensitivity: Sobol indices

Dividing each term in Equation (B.21) by the total variance defines the *Sobol indices* [sobol1993]:

$$S_i = \frac{V_i}{\text{Var}(G)}, \quad S_{ij} = \frac{V_{ij}}{\text{Var}(G)}, \quad (\text{B.22})$$

where:

- S_i is the **first-order Sobol index**: fraction of the output variance due to X_i alone.
- S_{ij} is the **second-order Sobol index**: fraction due to the interaction between X_i and X_j , beyond their individual effects.

The **total-order Sobol index** captures the full effect of X_i , including all interactions:

$$S_{T_i} = S_i + \sum_{j \neq i} S_{ij} + \cdots \quad (\text{B.23})$$

By construction, the first-order indices sum to at most one ($\sum_i S_i \leq 1$), and the total-order indices sum to at least one ($\sum_i S_{T_i} \geq 1$). When the model is additive (no interactions), $S_{ij} = 0$ for all pairs and $S_i = S_{T_i}$.

The first-order index S_i can be expressed as a conditional variance:

$$S_i = \frac{\text{Var}_{X_i}[\mathbb{E}_{X_{\sim i}}(G \mid X_i)]}{\text{Var}(G)}, \quad (\text{B.24})$$

where $X_{\sim i}$ denotes all variables except X_i . Intuitively, $\mathbb{E}(G \mid X_i)$ averages out all other variables: if this conditional mean varies a lot with X_i , then X_i is influential.

A variable with a large S_i (or S_{T_i}) is a *dominant parameter*: it drives most of the output uncertainty and should be characterised with care. A variable with a small index could be treated as deterministic without significant loss of accuracy.

B.4.3 Practical sensitivity approximation

Computing exact Sobol indices requires a large number of model evaluations. A simpler approach, used by the expansion of Englishquadrature method (Appendix B.3), estimates the contribution of each variable one at a time:

1. Fix all variables at their mean except X_i .
2. Run the model at each quadrature point of X_i to obtain the marginal variance $\hat{\sigma}_i^2$.
3. Repeat for every variable.

The **contribution** of X_i to the total output variability is then:

$$C_i = \frac{\hat{\sigma}_i^2}{\sum_{j=1}^N \hat{\sigma}_j^2} \times 100 \% \approx S_i \quad \text{when } S_{ij} \approx 0. \quad (\text{B.25})$$

A variable with $C_i \approx 0 \%$ has negligible influence and could be treated as deterministic. This approximation is valid when variables are uncorrelated and interaction effects are small. The detailed results are presented in ??.

B.5 Probability of failure and reliability index

B.5.1 Limit state function

In the sensitivity analysis (Section 5.5), $G = g(X_1, \dots, X_N)$ denoted the model output without any notion of safety or failure. In reliability analysis, the same symbol G is given an additional meaning: its *sign* now defines whether the structure is safe or has failed.

Specifically, G is rewritten as a **performance function** (also called limit-state function or safety margin) [2]. A simple example: if R is the material resistance and S is the applied load, then $G = R - S$. The structure is safe when $G > 0$ and fails when $G \leq 0$:

$$G(\mathbf{X}) > 0 \Rightarrow \text{safety domain } D_s, \quad G(\mathbf{X}) \leq 0 \Rightarrow \text{failure domain } D_f. \quad (\text{B.26})$$

In the simple case of a resistance R and a load effect S , the performance function writes $G(R, S) = R - S$ [2].

B.5.2 Probability of failure

The probability of failure is defined as [2]:

$$P_f = \text{Prob}[G(\mathbf{X}) \leq 0] = \int_{D_f} f_{\mathbf{X}}(\mathbf{x}) d\mathbf{x}, \quad (\text{B.27})$$

where $f_{\mathbf{X}}$ is the joint PDF of the random input vector. This integral is generally intractable for complex systems, which motivates the use of reliability indices.

B.5.3 Reliability indices

Given P_f from Equation (B.27), the *generalized reliability index* is defined as [15]:

$$\hat{\beta} = -\Phi^{-1}(\hat{P}_f), \quad (\text{B.28})$$

where Φ is the standard normal CDF. This definition applies to both the quadrature method (where $\hat{P}_f$ is obtained from the reconstructed CDF, Appendix B.3.3) and Monte Carlo simulation (where $\hat{P}_f$ is the empirical failure ratio, Appendix B.2).

Remark: Classical reliability theory also defines the Cornell index $\beta_C = \mu_G/\sigma_G$ and the Hasofer–Lind index β_{HL} (minimum distance to the failure surface in the standard normal space) [2, 1]. The Cornell index is exact only for linear limit states; the Hasofer–Lind index is used in FORM/SORM methods. Neither is employed in this work; for details, the reader is referred to [2, 1].



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EDUCATION

Université Grenoble Alpes

Sep 2025 - Present

Master 2: Geomechanics, Civil Engineering & Risks

Grenoble, France

- **M2 Semester 1 Grade:** 13.47/20 (Admis).
- **Key Coursework:** Numerical Methods for Nonlinear Mechanics, Durability and Vulnerability of Structures (15.8/20), Quantitative Image Analysis for Mechanics (16/20).
- **Thesis:** Numerical and experimental study of the THM behavior of concrete under severe accident conditions using a poro-mechanical approach.

Ho Chi Minh University of Technology

Sep 2019 - Jun 2024

Engineering Degree in Building & Energy (PFIEV Program)

HCM City, Vietnam

- **GPA:** 8.06/10 (3.5/4.0) | **Rank:** 3/12 (Excellence Program).
- **Honors:** University Semester Scholarships for 4 consecutive years (2021-2024)

RESEARCH & PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

M2 Research Intern / Thesis Student

Feb 2026 - Present

3SR Laboratory, Université Grenoble Alpes

Grenoble, France

- **Repository:** github.com/tankiet1907/cast3m-m2internship
- Investigating the thermo-hydro-mechanical (THM) behavior of concrete under severe accident conditions using a poro-mechanical approach.
- Developing and implementing numerical behavior models within the **Cast3M** finite element code using GIBIANE.
- Utilizing probabilistic and statistical methods to conduct sensitivity analyses and optimize THM coupling parameters.
- Correlating numerical simulations with experimental data to validate predictive models for structural integrity.

Structure Engineer (Full Time)

Aug 2024 - Aug 2025

GBC Engineers Vietnam

Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam

- Prepared Finite Element Models (FEM) and structural models for rigorous mechanical analysis.
- Delivered structural calculations, analysis reports, and correspondence ensuring compliance with international standards (Eurocode, TCVN).

Site Engineer (Internship)

Jun 2023 - Aug 2023

Unicons Construction (Member of Coteccons Group)

Binh Duong, Vietnam

- **Project:** LEGO Manufacturing Vietnam (Phase 1) – Moulding Building.
- Supervised structural fire protection implementations (Fire Protection Boards, Intumescent Paint, Concrete-encasement) to meet rigorous 120-minute Fire Protection Ratings.
- Optimized the execution schedule by transitioning the concrete encasement casting for columns from vertical to horizontal pouring.
- Conducted Quality Control per EC2: inspected steel frame erection via total station, verified tightening forces for Snug and Bearing bolts, and supervised Sika grouting and composite decking.

PROJECTS

Scientific Research: Fire-Resistant Steel Structures

Sep 2023 - Dec 2023

Ho Chi Minh City University of Technology

Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam

- Evaluated thermo-mechanical properties of steel at high temperatures per EUROCODE specifications.
- Designed and verified fire-resistant structural elements (columns and beams) using advanced material models.

CERTIFICATIONS & AWARDS

- **Third Prize, 36th Loa Thanh Award (2024):** National award for the most prestigious graduation projects in civil engineering.
- **Third Prize in Physics (2018):** City Level Excellent Student Competition (Ho Chi Minh City).
- **Certificate of Merit:** Recognized as a "Very Good Student" for the 2021-2022 academic year.

SKILLS & COMPETENCIES

Technical: Cast3M (Advanced), Finite Element Analysis (FEA), THM Coupling, Probabilistic Sensitivity Analysis.

Software: LaTeX, Linux Mint, VS Code, Revit Structure, AutoCAD, ETABS, SAP2000, MS Office.

Languages: Vietnamese (Native), English (Advanced - TOEIC: 935/990), French (Intermediate - TCF TP: 347/699, B1).

EXTRACURRICULAR ACTIVITIES

- **Main Vocal:** Tet Festival of the Vietnamese Community in Grenoble. 2026
- **Main Vocal:** PFIEV Freshman Welcome Party (2023) and Journée de la Culture Française (2022). 2022 - 2023
- **Volunteer:** Supporting COVID-19 prevention work.
- **Security Support:** Admissions Consulting Day (2022) and University Entrance Exam Support Program (2020). 2020 - 2022.

